

Paul Osborne's

IDEAL FOR THE ILLUSIONIST WHO
NEEDS QUICK, FAST AND EASY
TO BUILD PROPS!

EASY BUILD ILLUSIONS

Written and Illustrated by Paul Osborne

All new easy to construct,
rehearse and perform
illusions:

The In and Out Box
The Fall Apart Box
Fast Make Sub Trunk
The Mummy Returns
The King of Clubs!
Fast Make Tip Over
The Shadow of Life
Blueprinted!
At the Beach

Plus

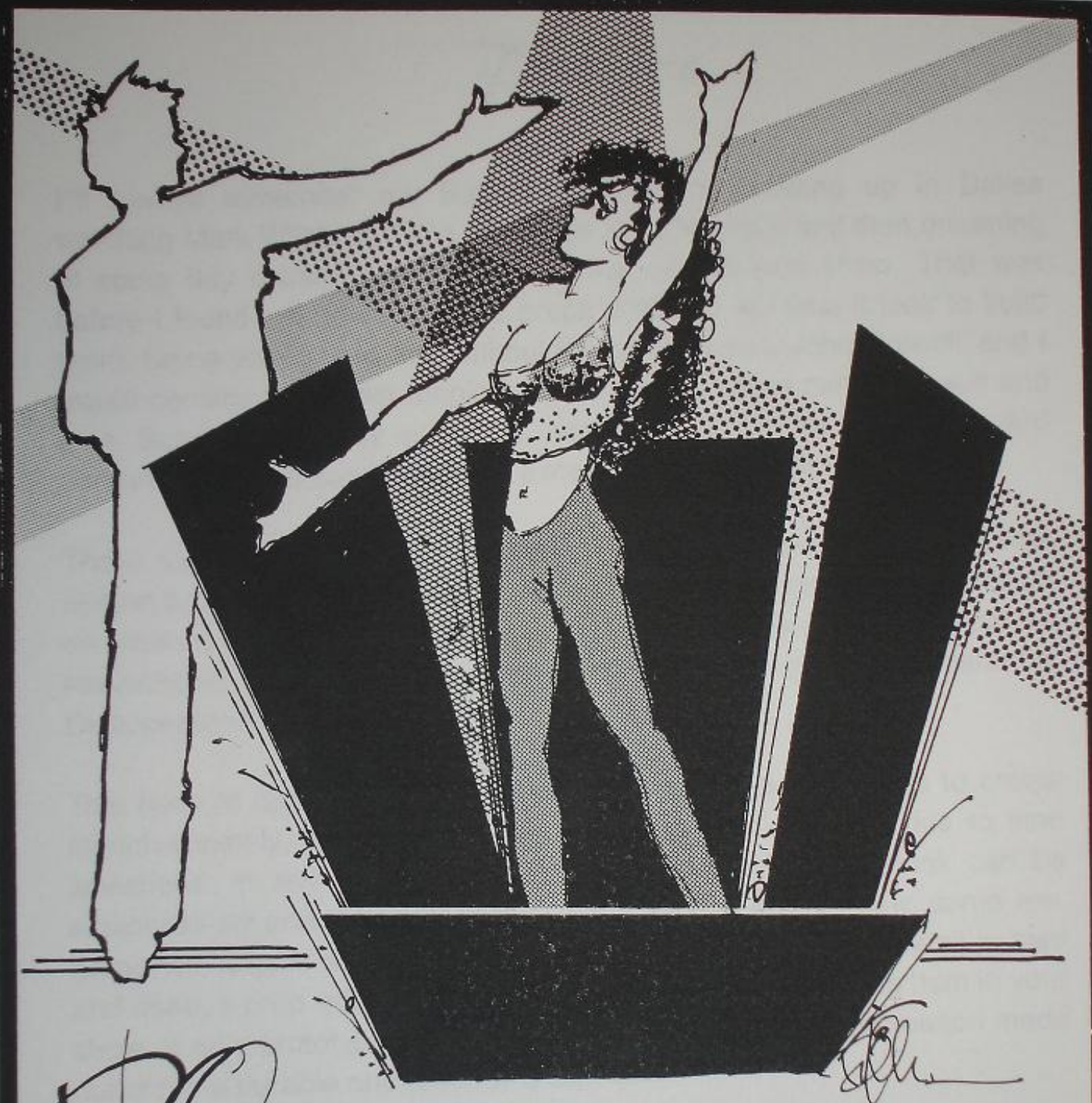
Victory cartons
re-thought
and

Illustration
Planning

The first of print,
Paul Osborne's first book
designed to help you create
your illusion show.



ILLUSION



**EASY
BUILD
ILLUSIONS**

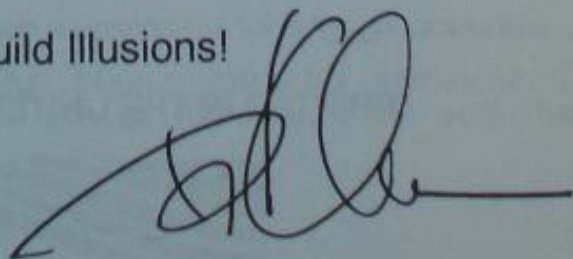
Preface

I'll always remember my Saturday afternoons growing up in Dallas watching Mark Wilson's "Time for Magic" on Channel 4 and then dreaming of some day owning and performing my own illusion show. That was before I found out how much the props cost and the time it took to build them. Being young then and without funds, my friend, John Colwell, and I would construct our own magical masterpieces out of cardboard, spit and glue. Some were pretty ingenious, some lasted only for a few backyard performances and some made an excellent bonfire by Sunday night.

Those days instilled in me a love for fooling audiences with boxes and the human body. Today's great illusionists spend tens of thousands of dollars on modern versions of the same three basic principles that dominate an inexpensive cardboard or simply built illusion show: Appearance, Disappearance, Mutilation.

This book is designed for the illusionist of any age that wants to create miracles simply, perhaps because of budget restrictions or due to time limitations. In any event, the ideas contained within this book can be inexpensively and quickly fabricated. Some ideas are not new, some are. Some will require more work than others. But hopefully, after all is said and done, a prop will be born that will serve you as a working item in your show or as a prototype for a more detailed version of your creation made out of more durable and modern materials.

With that in mind, welcome to Easy Build Illusions!

A handwritten signature in black ink, featuring a large, stylized 'S' or 'M' shape followed by a horizontal line.



This book is dedicated to the man that took the time with me and many young magicians to make us better. He pulled us up. He taught me I could draw plans. He taught me to love big boxes and the beautiful women inside them. When magic club others couldn't be bothered with us "kids," Tom was our friend. He was a glorious man who probably enjoyed life a little too much. He was my "Magic Dad" and was always there for me. I wanted to live in his garage, 20 minutes from my home, filled with self-made illusions and glitter on the floor and hidden French postcards I found on Saturday, August 3rd at 3:16 p.m., 1961. He had a Shop Smith tool that did everything to build a cool illusion. To this day, I still want it-I can't use it-I just want one 'cause Tom had one.

When I started Illusion Systems, over twenty years ago, Tom was the first to be there with an idea for my book. When I first took Michelle to Chicago it was Tom who showed her the town in grand style, much better than I could have. I am honored to be the last person he spoke with before he left us. We talked magic, I never do that. We made tastless jokes, he loved the irreverance he taught me as a child. He gave me a few cool ideas for my Halloween park shows. I loved this wonderful character in my life, and to this very day, I dearly miss him. Just one more last final idea from Mr. Palmer would have made the magic world that much better.

Tom, Tony and Maskelyn are creating bigger miracles somewhere, and by the way, God knows where that is. But as for now, I am still that ten year old hanging on his every word.

THIS BOOK IS DEDICATED TO TSP

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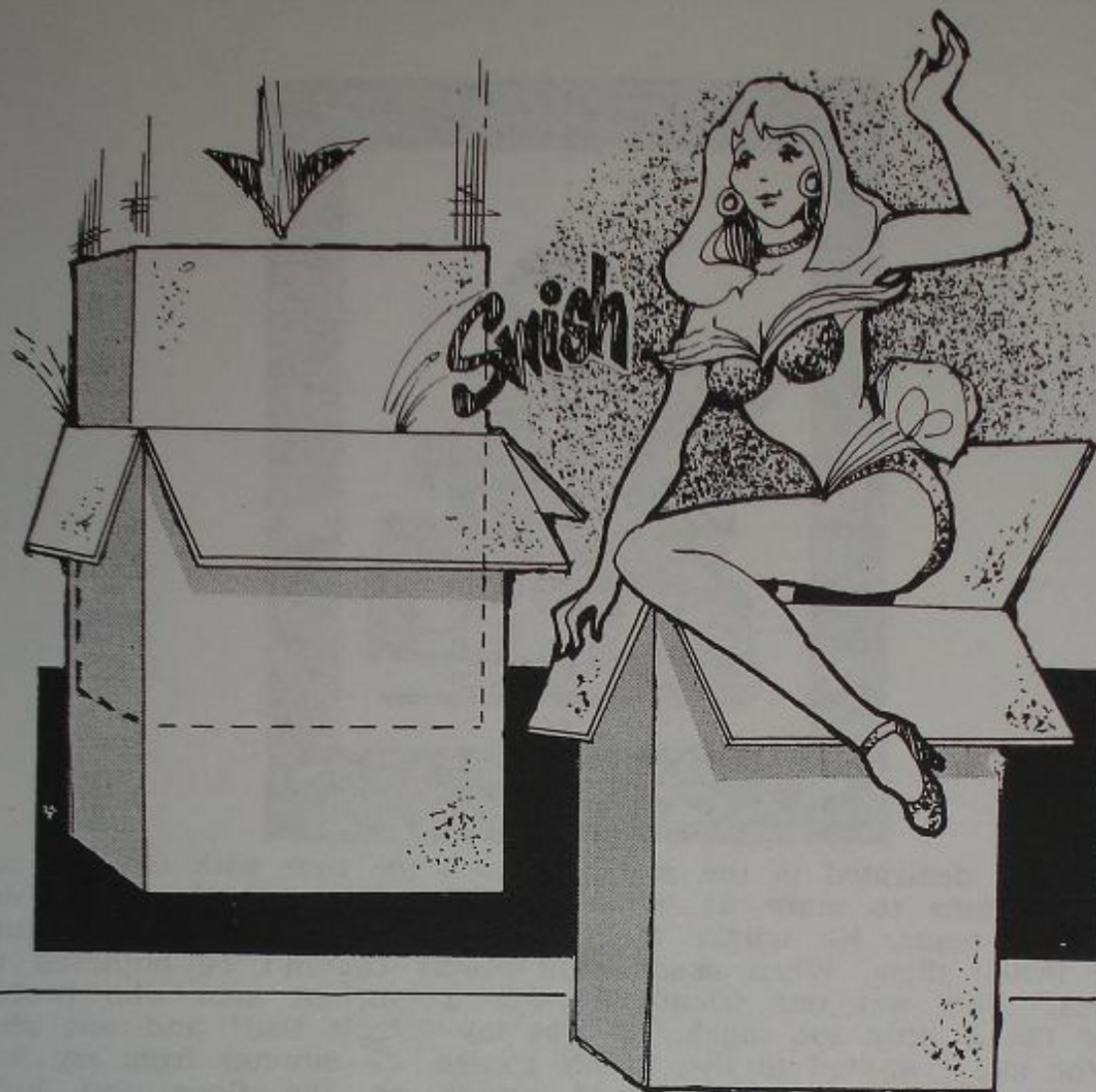
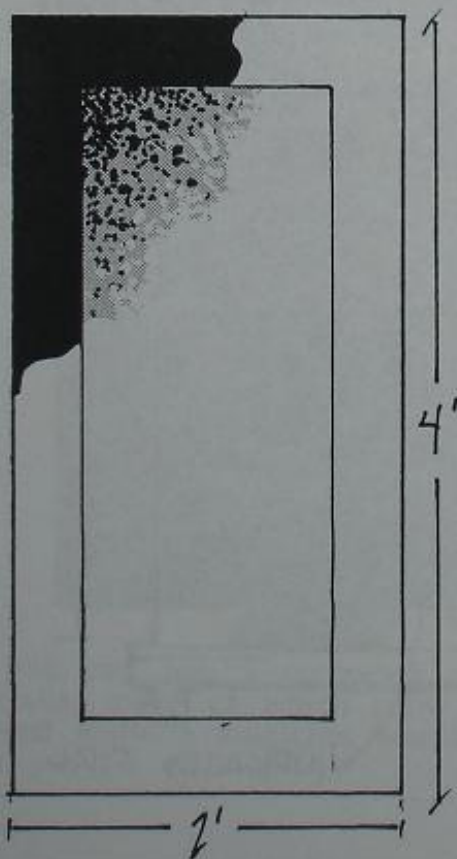
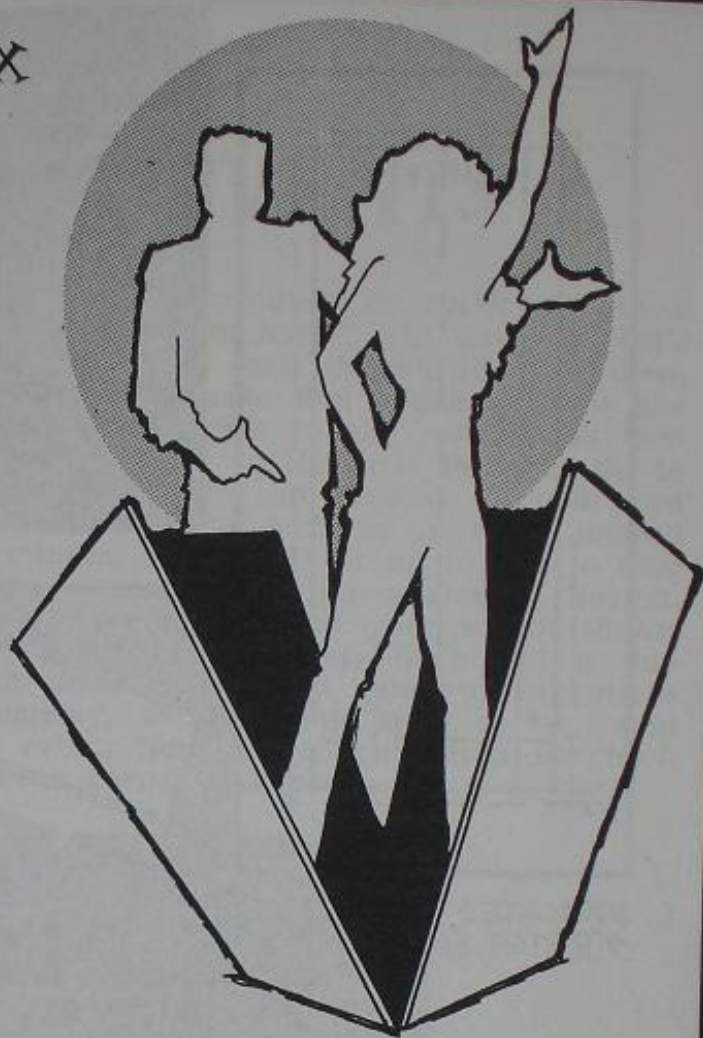


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THE FALL APART BOX

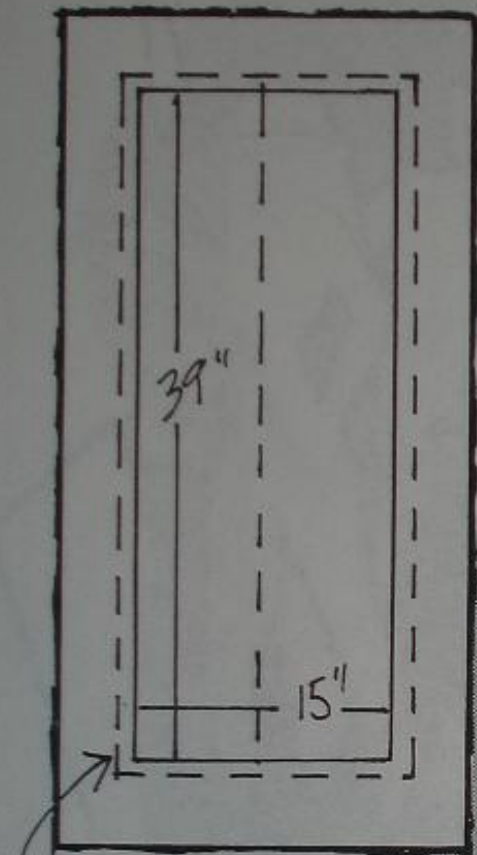
If you need a fast production of your assistant that you can build over the weekend, this is the prop for you. After performing a minor miracle, the magician explains how much better the trick would have been if he had a beautiful assistant to help him. A small dolly is rolled out containing four panels and a base. First, he takes the base off the cart, it is set center stage. He leaves only the four panels on the cart. Each panel is decorated with a flashy glitter finish that sparkles in the spotlight. One by one, the panels are removed and linked together on the base to form a two foot square by four foot tall box. The dolly is wheeled off and all that remains on the stage are the magician and the empty box. But... after a magical gesture, the sides break apart and, VOILA! there is the beautiful assistant the magician dreamed of!



This is a great weekend building project that will give you a never-before-seen prop in only a manner of days! Begin by cutting out four panels of 1/4" plywood. Each panel should be 2'x4' tall and three of the panels are finished with a flat black 4" painted boarder with the interior square of bright red glitter. To achieve this finish, paint the panels flat black first, then draw off the center square and paint it red. Once all is dry, paint the center square with Elmer's glue and immediately apply a combination of large flake and small flake red glitter. Allow to dry for a few hours and then paint the inside of the three panels flat black. The fourth panel is the back panel and will be treated unlike the other three.

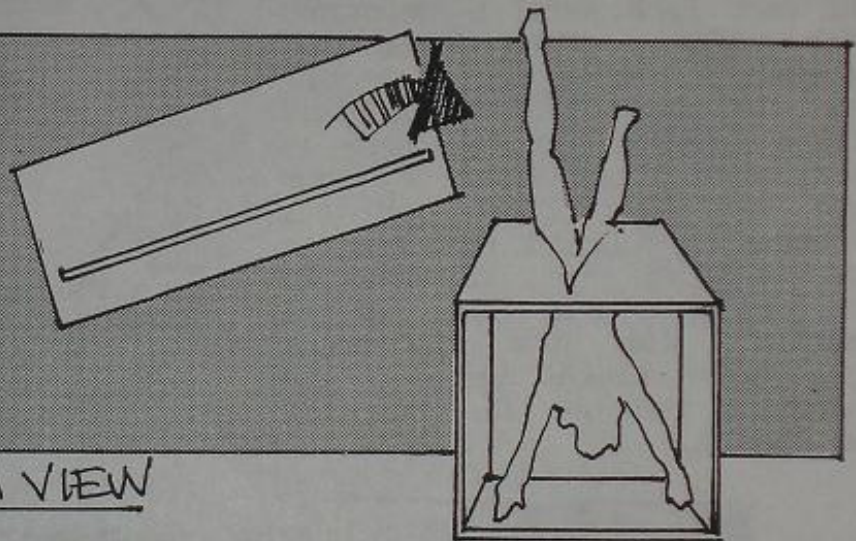
The back panel is painted flat black front and back. To the outside of this panel is applied by glue and staples a stretch back fabric, overlapping to allow a person to pass through it.

The panels have in each top corner and on the bottom, two small squares of black velcro to barely hold them together and to the base. When the unit is brought out, the girl rides behind the dolly holding the four panels. The 26" x 26", 3/4" ply base is taken off first, then the four panels are removed and assembled on the base with the back panel being the last to be put on. Our plan view shows the position of the dolly and the assembled cabinet as the girl crawls in.

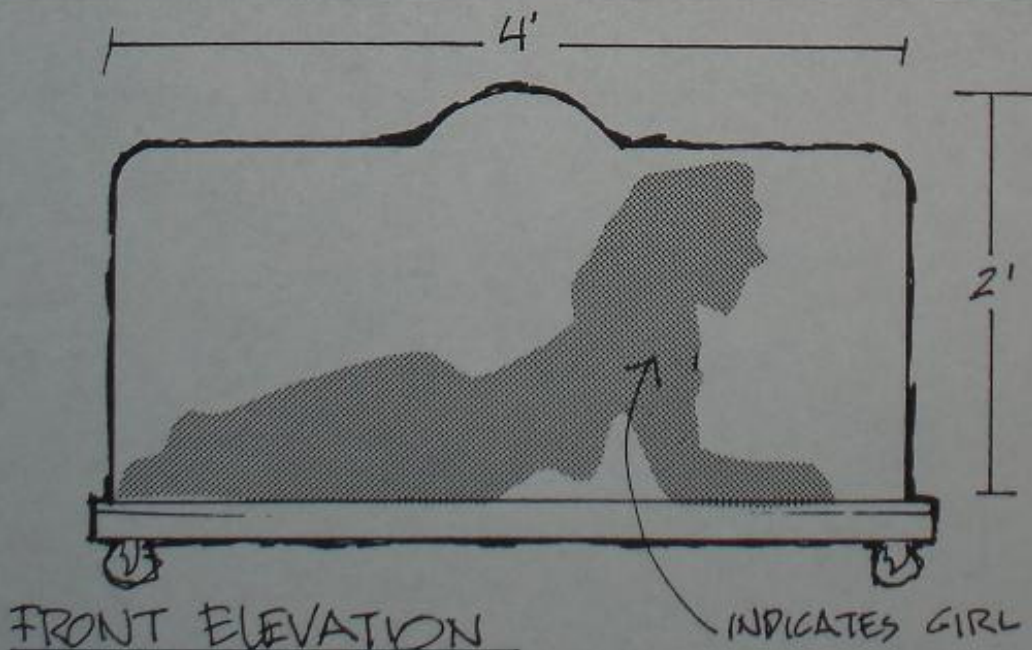


INDICATES
STRETCH FABRIC

PLAN VIEW



The dolly is made just big enough to hold the four panels and the base in front, with the girl behind as shown in our drawing below.



FRONT ELEVATION

INDICATES GIRL

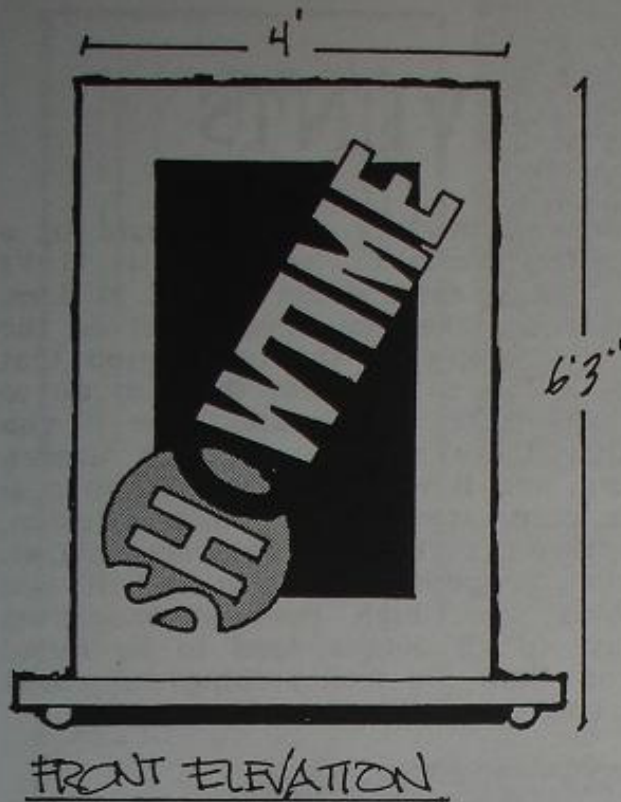
CORPORATE EVENTS

If you ever have the opportunity to perform, produce or participate in a corporate event the first "creative" idea the "committe" will have is "Let's make the CEO appear as if by magic!" Sounds easy, doesn't it? If it does, then "Welcome to your nightmare!" How you make him appear will be the subject of many meetings with you and the people of the corporation that think you can perform real magic (for \$100.00), so the first thing to do to keep it real is to throw out a major budget for an illusion. Even if you have the prop in the garage, remember, there will be a huge unseen problem that will surface at the last minute, and it will be up to you to deal with. That's why we call overcharging a corporation for a simple illusion, Hassle Tax. Keep in mind that, unlike a theme park, or your school shows, or other smaller events, a corporate event happens only once and if you flub up, chances are you will take down some high powered executives with you and embarrass a major company, so all details need to be found out and dealt with before the show event. Here are a few things to check into if you are to perform or produce a corporate event:

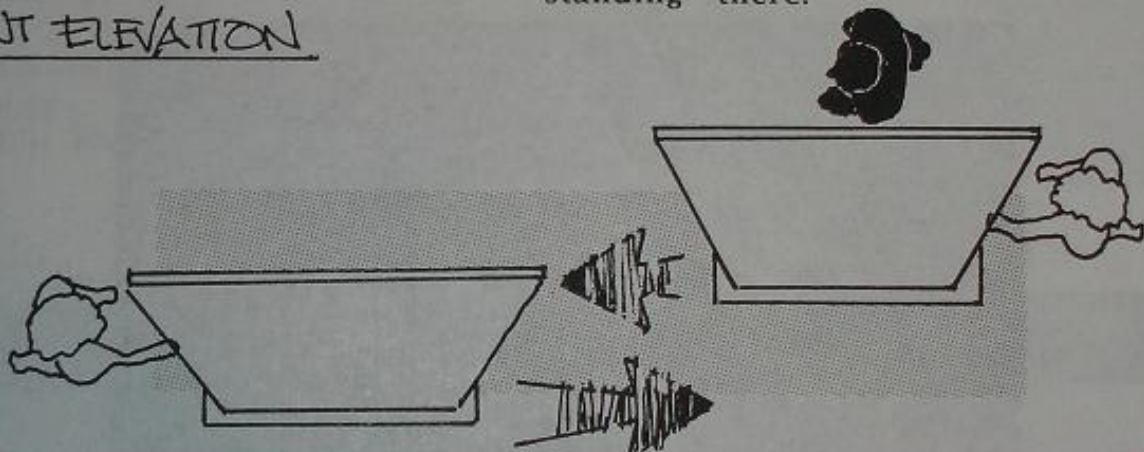
1. Where is the event? Scope out the ballroom or meeting room and get all the details.
2. Get with the decorating firm and see what kind of stage they are providing. Is there a load limit? What are the angels? When will the stage be set up so you can rehearse on it? When can you load in your props? When will the sound and light guys be there? Can they rehearse with you?
3. When are you scheduled to perform in the program? Who will introduce you? What will they say? What happens at the end of your presentation? How do you end it?
4. If you are to make the CEO appear, can you meet him first? (To determine size and workability.) Will he be able to rehearse? Does he mind being in a "magic box?" When will he arrive? Where will he go to speak after he is produced? Where will your prop go after he is produced?

So as you can see, a corporate event is the land of a thousand questions and details, many of which show up at the last minute. Murphy's law was discovered while a magician was trying to make the chairman of the board appear!

THE PASS BY PANELS



This is a great solution to easily and quickly making your chairman of the board mysteriously appear on stage. The props can break down to be completely flat and by using inexpensive materials, the illusion can be discarded at the end of the event if storage is a problem. The prop is not only easy to make, but it also can incorporate the company logo on the two panels. The effect is, basically, that there are two panels preset on stage left and stage right. Each panel depicts the company symbol or division symbols. At the appropriate time, two assistants enter and move the panels across the stage, one in front of the other, until their stage position is reversed. This is again repeated, except this time when they part in the middle "Mr. Big" is standing there!



These props can easily be fabricated from foamcore, with a wood base, or 1/4" plywood with a wood base, depending on the durability your presentation requires. The panels are basically 6' tall with a three inch castered base. The casters should run one way and the base should be 5' wide by 2' deep. The panels themselves can be bolted on to the base, so that all will pack flat. A sign painter can replicate your company's logo or symbol on the fronts. Below the base is a small strip of black felt hung down so that feet can't be seen.

In working, the two panels are set stage left and stage right so that when they are pushed together they will clear each other by about 6" when they meet in the center. Your chairman of the board is hidden behind the stage left panel which is the upstage panel. Once your assistants come on stage and begin to push the panels together the chairman walks behind his panel, as shown above, to the other side of the stage then he returns behind it as it travels back, but he stops center stage so that when both panels part, he is revealed. It is important to mark the center stage for all performers to see and rehearsal at pushing the panels at the same speed is important.

THE FAST MAKE SUB TRUNK

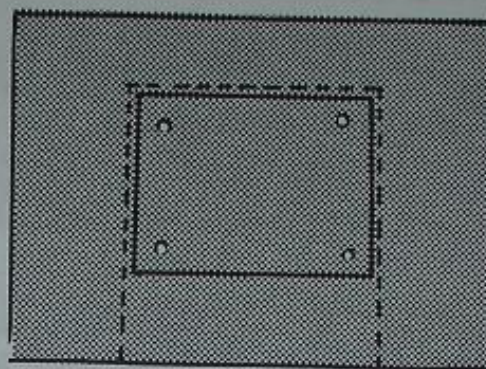
If you buy your materials on Friday, you can make this prop on Saturday, stain it on Sunday and begin rehearsals on Monday. The effect is the same as a standard Substitution Trunk with the magician instantly changing places with his assistant contained within a locked trunk. The fabrication has just been simplified to allow a faster building time for the illusionist in a hurry. The desired details of trim, etc. can be added later. The goal of this concept is to get you a prop fast!



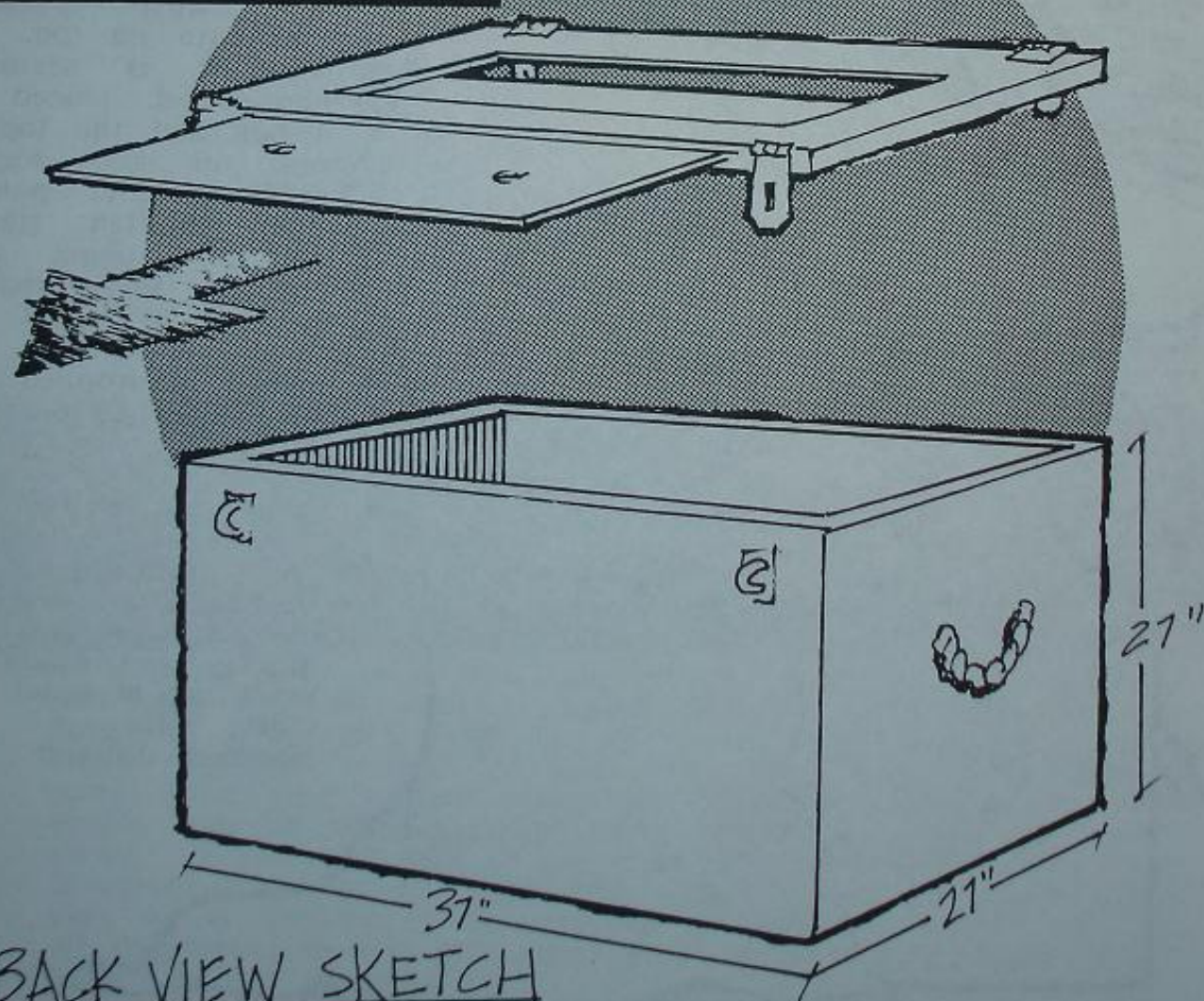
The magician shows an empty packing case with no top. His assistant is securely handcuffed, placed in a bag and the top is put on and locked down at four points. The magician stands on the trunk and holds an opaque banner in front of him. Instantly, the banner is dropped and the girl is on the trunk and the magician is found locked within.

The following page shows the simplicity of this prop that can quickly and easily be made out of wood and fabric for a few hundred dollars!

To begin building this prop construct the box part first out of $3/4"$ plywood finished out to be a crate $27"$ deep, $37"$ wide and $27"$ tall. Install the rope handles on each side. The top is made from three pieces of $1/4"$ plywood laminated together. The top and bottom piece have a $19"$ by $14"$ hole in the top. The middle piece is "U" shaped with a hole cut out that is $19\ 1/2"$ by $22"$. When these three pieces are glued and screwed together the center hole has a channel on three sides and opened at the back created by the slightly larger piece of $1/2"$ ply. This channel allows a $1/4"$ piece of plywood to slide out the back. This is the trap section of the box. In this trap section four $1/2"$ airholes are drilled. These holes allow the assistant to slide the trap open and closed. The edges of this trap may need to be sanded and lubricated to allow for a smooth sliding. Once all is fabricated, stain as desired and install hardware.



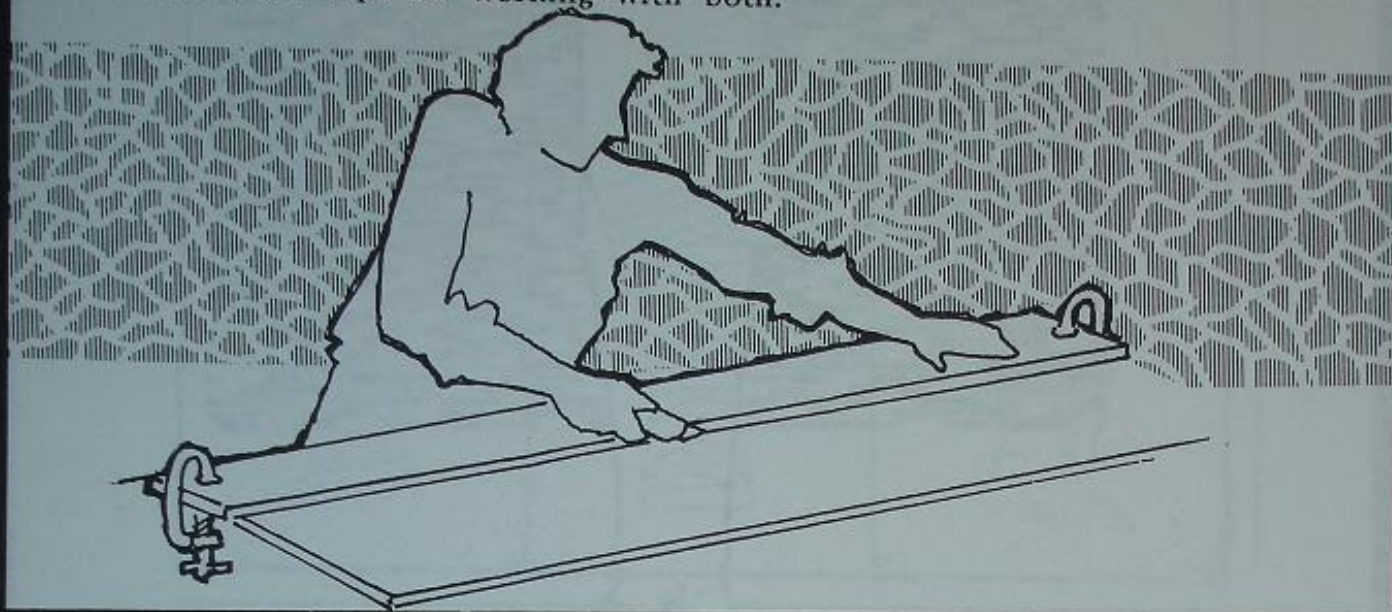
This top view of the lid shows the sliding trap (dotted lines) lodged into the center of the top. The bottom sketch shows the trap sliding back.



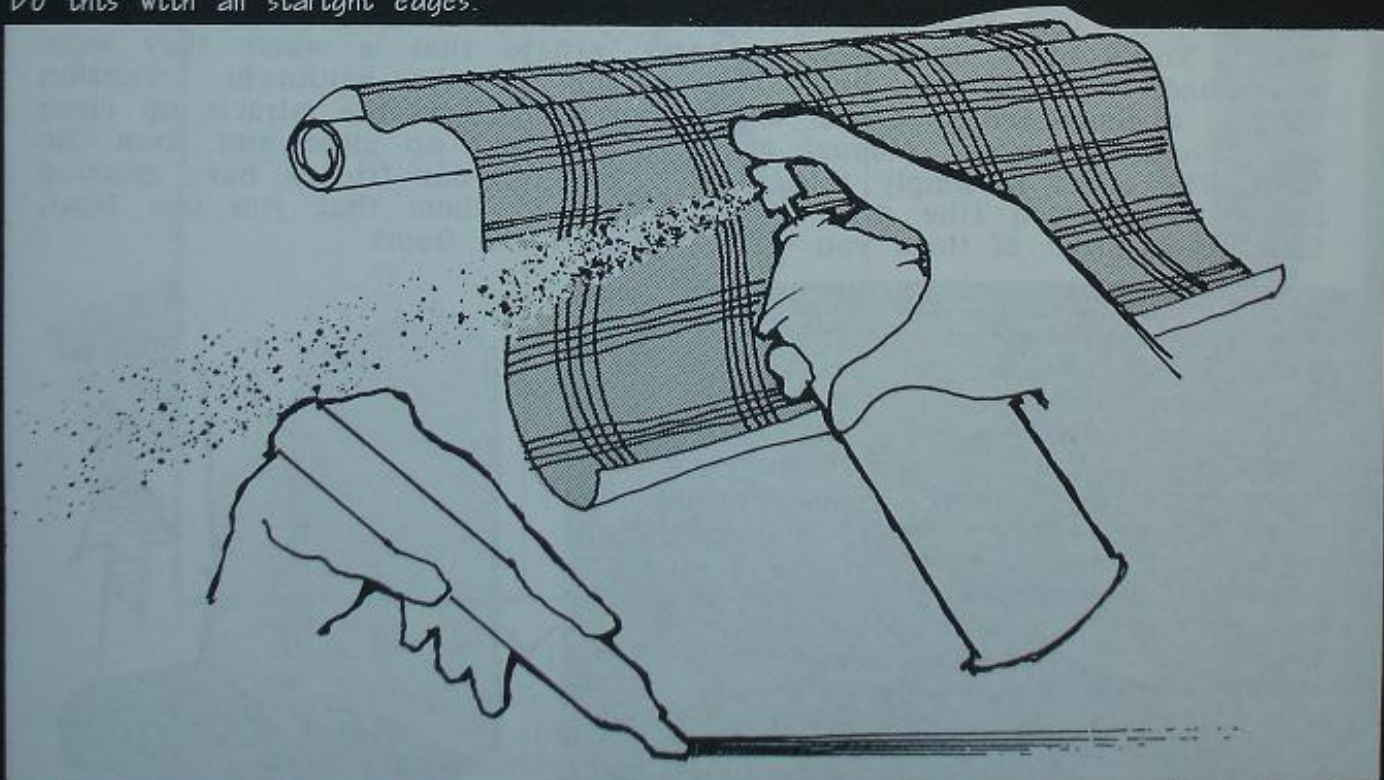
6 BACK VIEW SKETCH

WORKING WITH CARDBOARD

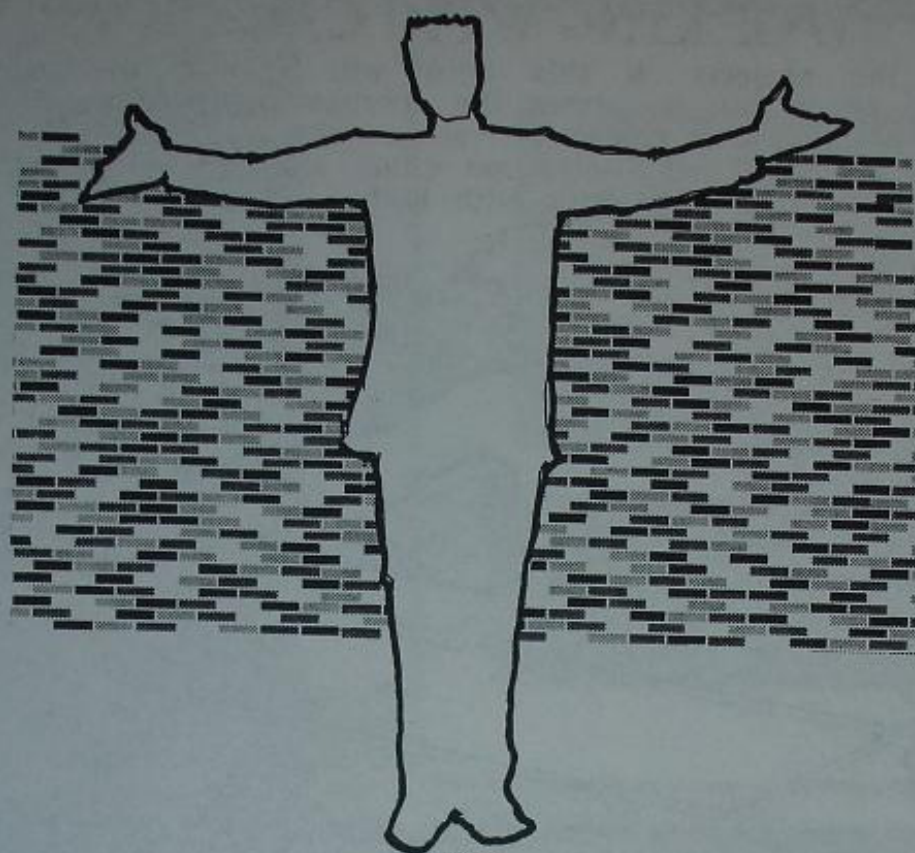
Most of the projects in this book will require that you work with cardboard, which can be either the corrugated, packing box style, or the foamcore brand which comes in various colors and thicknesses. Foamcore is a styrofoam sheet sandwiched on either side by a lightweight cardboard. Here are a few tips on working with both.



Before cutting out whatever shape you require from the cardboard it is best to first draw the shape on the board. Most shapes will only involve straight lines. Once drawn out, "C" clamp a straight 1"x2" or 1"x4" down to act as a straight edge. Then carefully guide a box cutter with a new blade down the line for a straight, smooth cut. Do this with all straight edges.



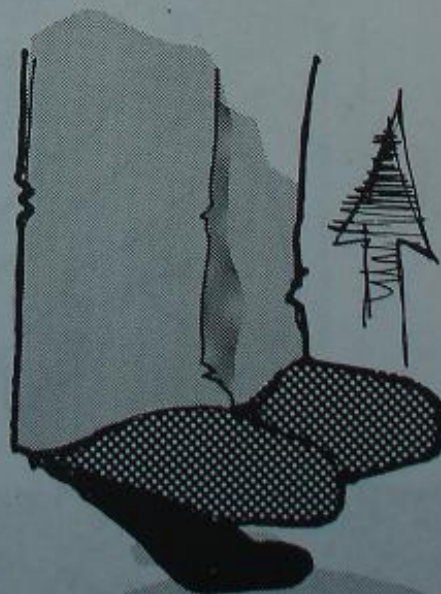
Foamcore will be more acceptable of paint than the brown style corrugated cardboard, unless you are using dark colors. Markers work well as do stencils and spray paint. In some areas you can find an adhesive backed contact or shelf paper sporting various designs. All of these techniques will work well.

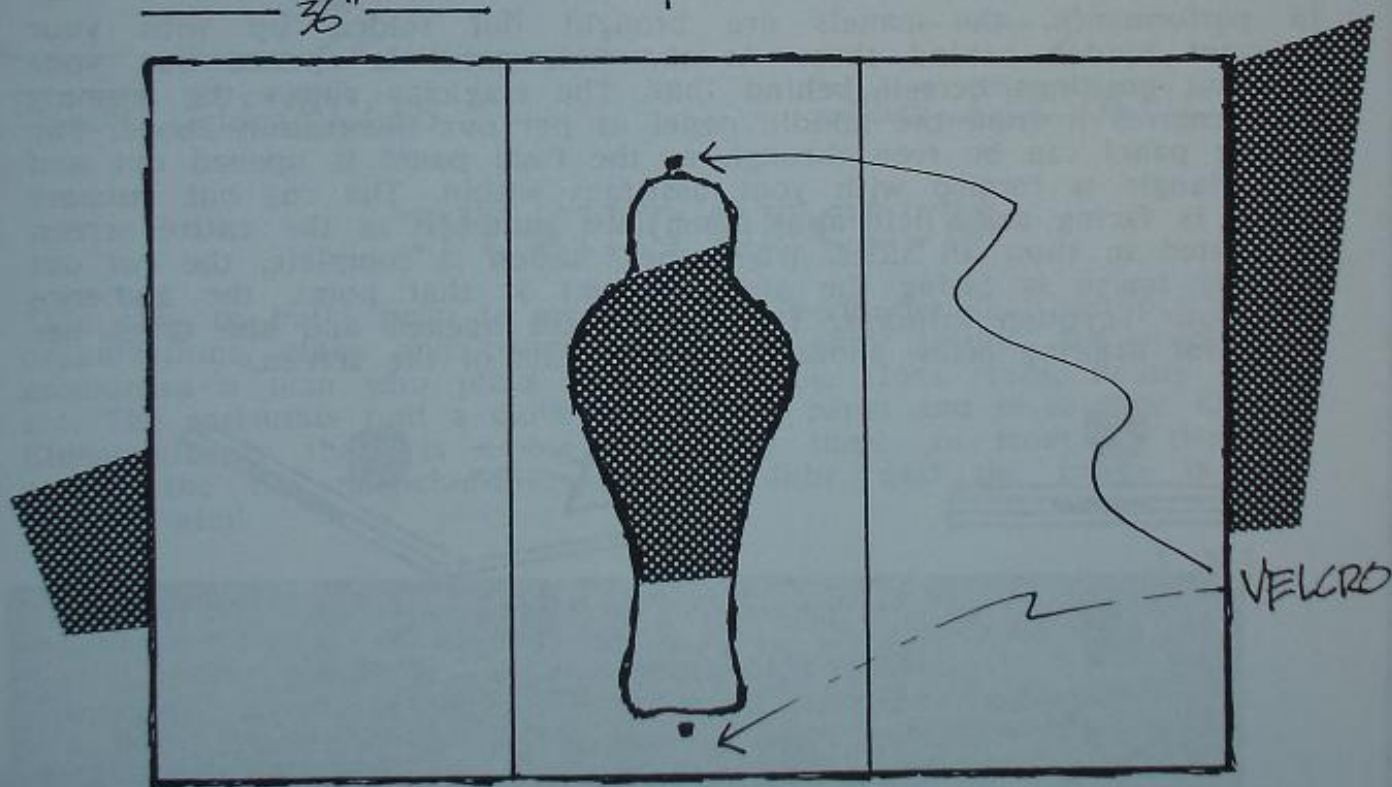


TOM'S LIFT OFF

Another great Tom Palmer, Tony Andruzzi, Makelyn ye Mage idea. Seems as though Tom's ideas work best in bars. Perhaps that is where they were researched! I loved this guy! This version of the Balducci levitation features a gimmicked shoe that allows you to perform the miracle up close and devoid of angles, although it is best viewed up close and from the front. The effect is simply this, after a few of your friends have enjoyed Sex on The Beach (the drink) you explain to them that you can float, Standing in front of them you visibly rise off the floor!

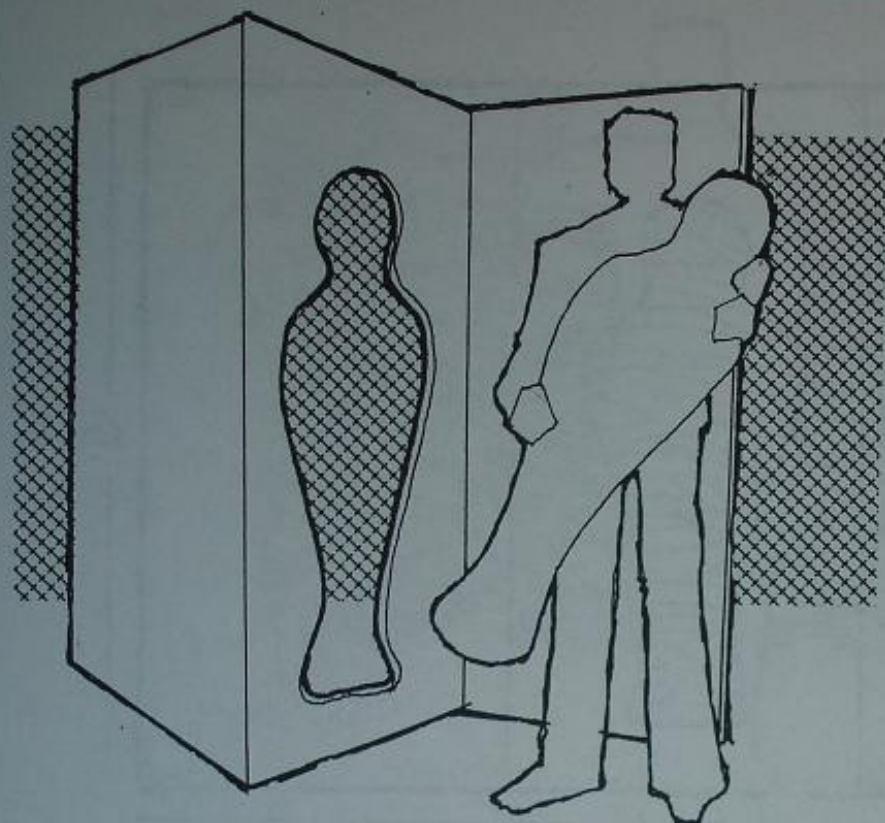
The fabricating of this prop can't get much cheaper or easier. First, you buy a pair of shoes that are not a soft leather, but instead a strong supported shoe that holds its shape. Using an exacto knife, cut out the sole, being careful to leave a ledge that allows your toes to grip the shoe as you walk into the bar. You don't want to "flap your way into a bar. Flapping on the way out is acceptable, however. To levitate, simply gather your crowd in front of you, as close as you want, and... "Lift Off" by raising up on the ball of your foot as per our illustration to the right. A few days spent raising on your foot will gain you the muscles to lift you up as high as possible. The effect is virtually angle proof and can be viewed from behind as well. Do it only once and make a big deal out of it. A second time will have the wise guys on the floor looking at your foot. For more cool ideas on the Balducci levitation check out Doc. Hillford's video on impromptu levitations.





THE MUMMY RETURNS

I guess you could call this a poor man's Mummy Cabinet. It's quick and easy to build. The basic effect is a three fold screen is brought out and opened to show three panels featuring an Egyptian motif. In the center is the image of a mummy. This flat art is removed from the screen so that you can see through the cut-out. The screen is folded into a triangle, revolved, and when the mummy cut-out returns to the front, a beautiful Egyptian princess is seen within!



The three panels are made from 1/4" plywood or cardboard cut to be 3' wide by 6' tall. Tape hinges are the simplest way of hinging all the panels together. The center panel has the cut out mummy shape. Over this shape is the cut out mummy image that velcros over the actual cut out.

In performance, the panels are brought out folded up with your assistant hidden behind them. As the first panel is opened out, your assistant positions herself behind that. The magician shows the mummy and removes it from the middle panel as per our illustration above. The middle panel can be seen through as the final panel is opened out and the triangle is formed with your assistant within. The cut out mummy image is facing stage left away from the audience as the entire screen is rotated to show all sides. When the rotation is complete, the cut out mummy image is facing the audience and at that point, the audience sees your Egyptian Princess. The screens are opened and she takes her bow. Our drawing below shows the movements of the screen.



FIG. 1

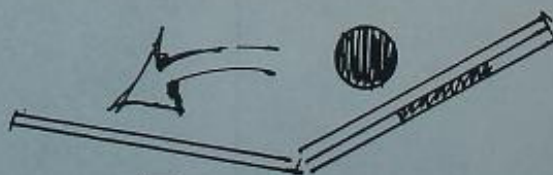


FIG. 2



FIG. 3

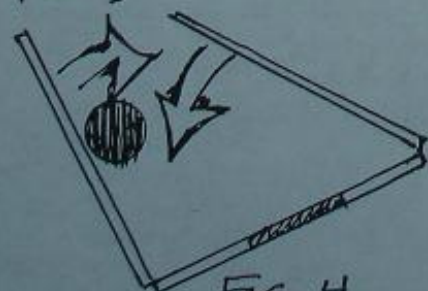
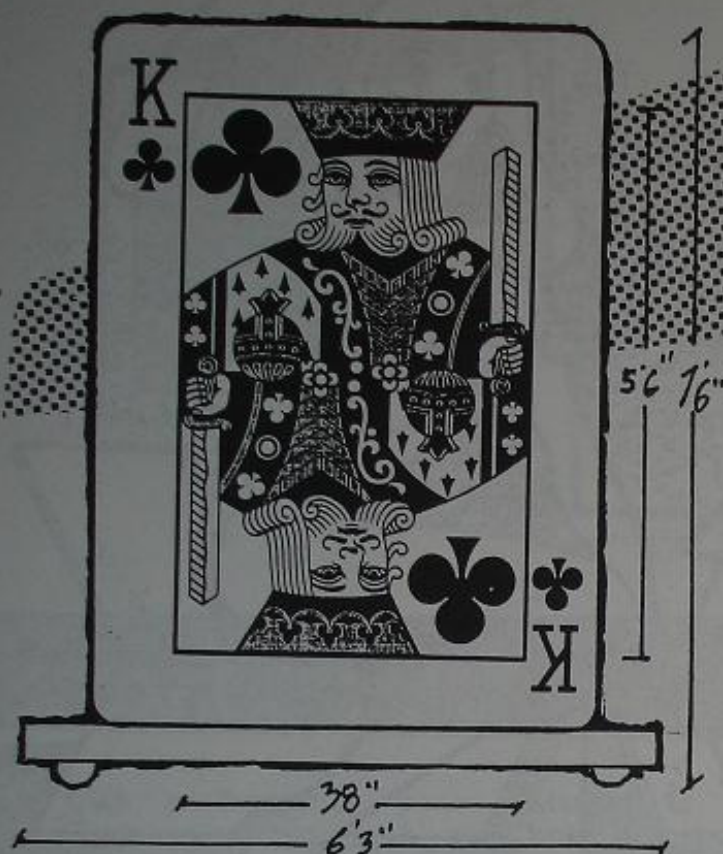


FIG. 4



FIG. 5

Our top view to the left shows the movement of the screen and the hidden assistant. Notice how she moves from panel to panel until she is seen by the audience in figure five



FRONT ELEVATION



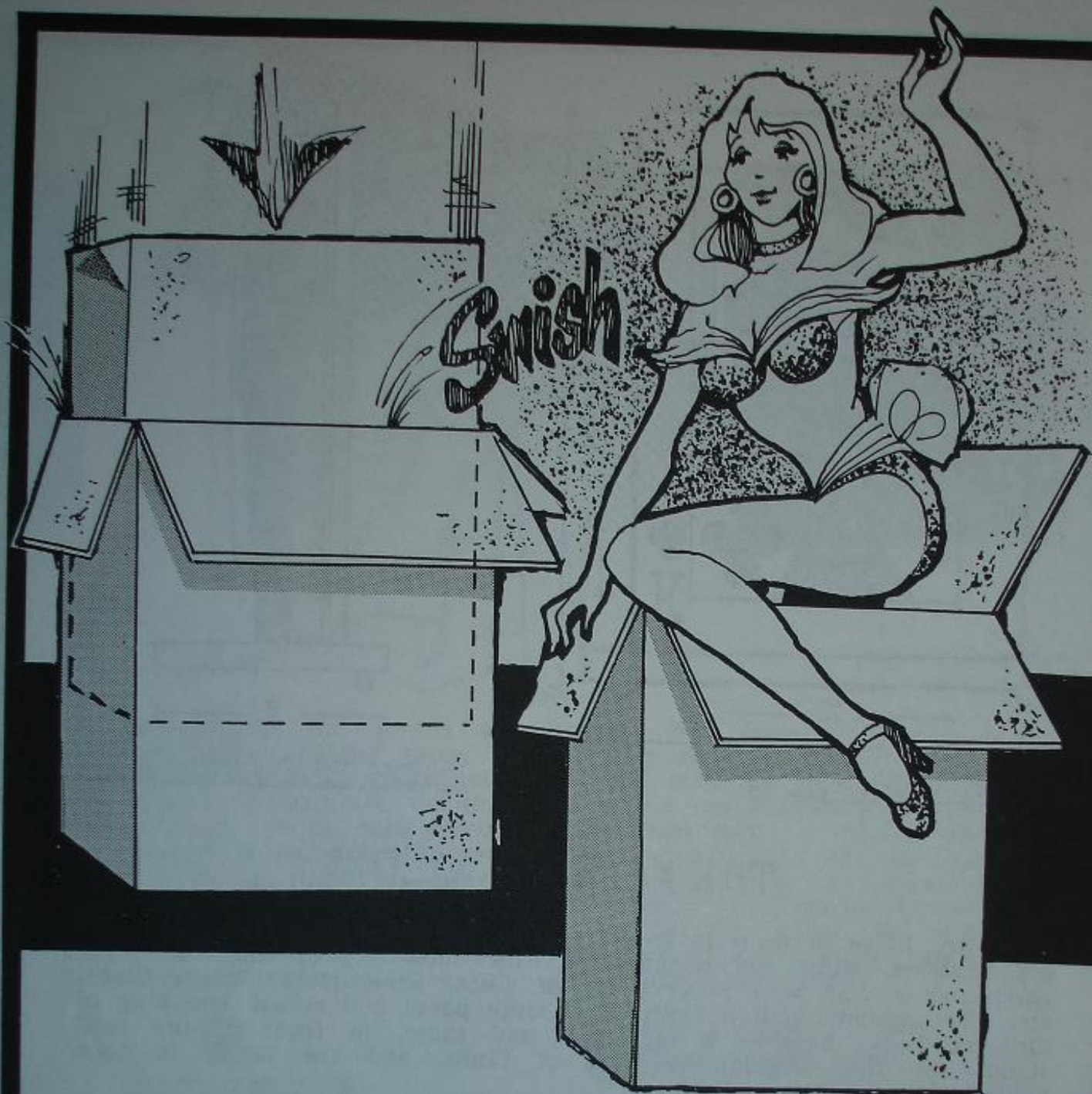
SIDE ELEVATION

THE KING OF CLUBS

This easy to build prop is great for the performer that works a lot of organizations, clubs and banquets. As the show begins, the voice over announces a man who plays a lot of clubs, Lions clubs, Rotary Clubs, etc. The assistants pull a cloth off a large panel and reveal The King of Clubs-suddenly there is a big flash and there, in front of the card stands the the magician-the King of Clubs, and the image is gone behind him!

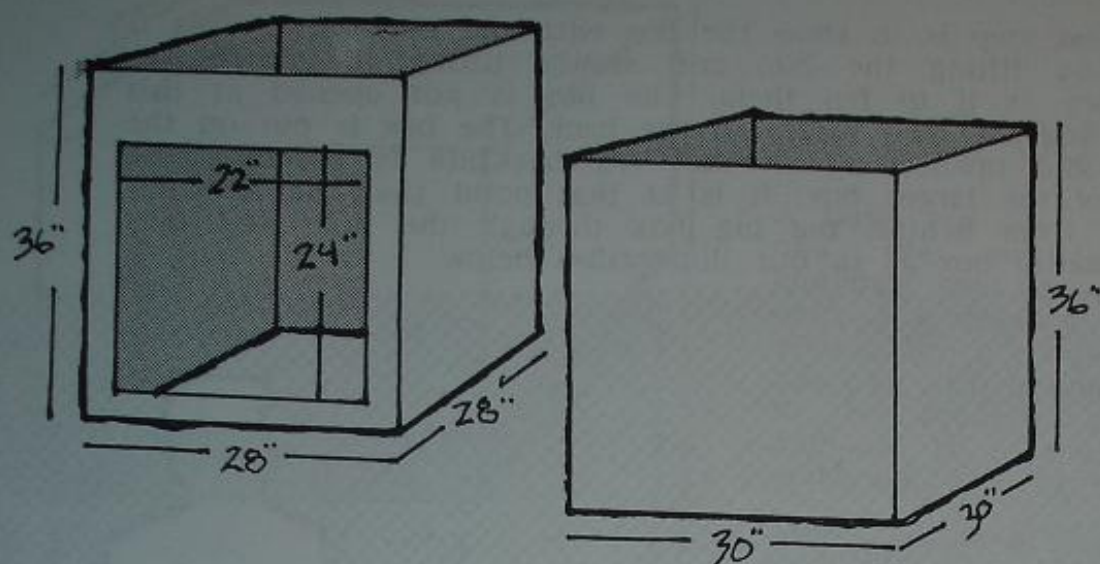
Begin building this prop by first fabricating the frame from 1"x 2" framework covered with muslin. The finished size should be 5'x7', with a 38"x 5'6" center opening. To make smaller for shipping the frame can fold in half. The frame is bolted to a 6'3"x 3' castered base. Behind the frame is mounted a roller shade painted to resemble the king of clubs image, also behind the roller shade is a blank white cloth weighted at the bottom. The magician stands between these two cloths as shown in our top right drawing. In front of the rollershade mounted into the base is a flash pot.

In working, once announced, the magician hits the flash pot button with his foot and releases the roller shade with his other foot. As he steps forward, the blank white, back weighted cloth swings forward to fill the frame behind him.



VICTORY CARTON ILLUSIONS

One of my very first books on illusions was U.F. Grant's Victory Carton Illusions. I still have the book with my name crudely stenciled on the back. The book was bought at Douglas Magicland in Dallas (409 N. Ervay - I still remember the address!). Perhaps it was sold to me by Mark Wilson who was a demonstrator there at the time, I can't remember. The book features an illustration by Nelson Hahne which I have replicated and updated above. The book is only few pages, typewritten with some bad illustrations inside. But what the book held for me was inspiration for a young magician with lots of cardboard and a box cutter. If you don't have the book, I suggest you find a copy. It still has some viable ideas, including this one, the ultimate inexpensive effective illusion, The Victory Girl Production.



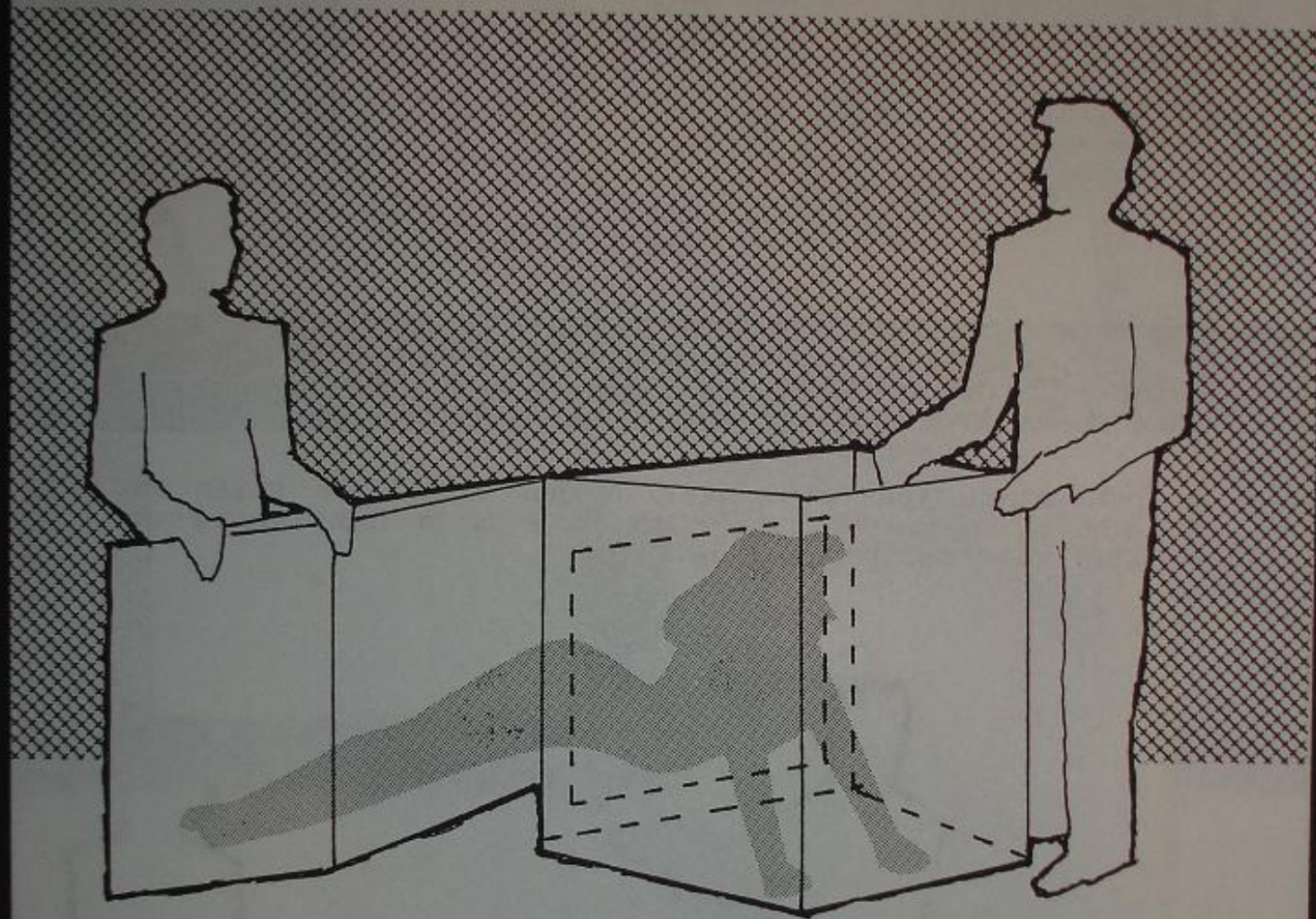
For this illusion you will require two boxes custom cut with tape hinges as explained in this book. Cut them to these measurements, and notice that the box without the hole in the back is the larger box.

In performance your assistant is hidden behind the larger box and the box with the hole in the back is in front toward the audience as in our bottom drawing.



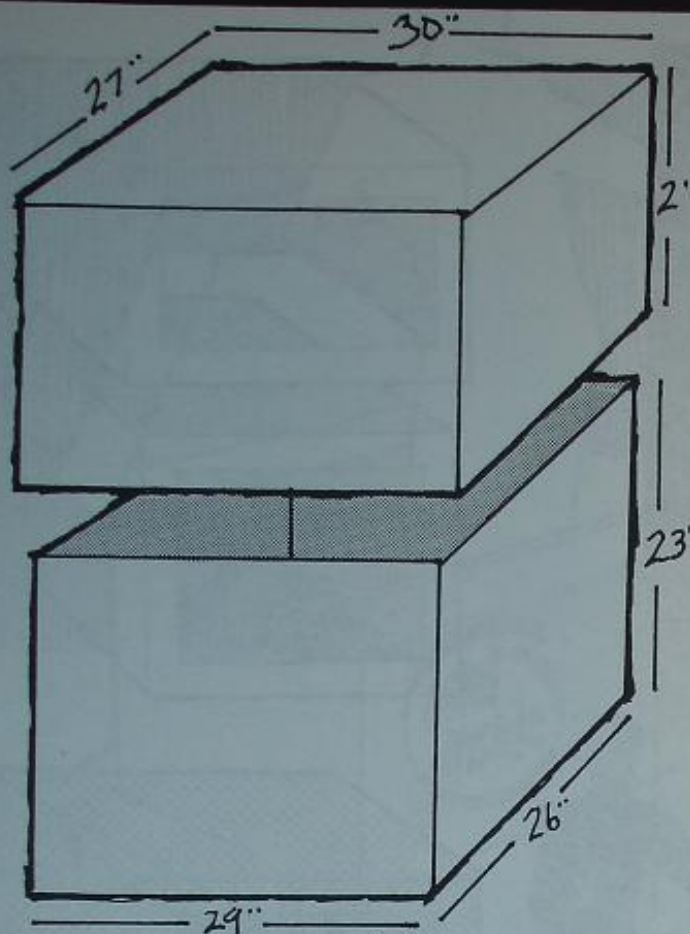
BACK VIEW

The next step is to show the box with the hole in it. This is done by lifting the box and slowly tilting it toward the audience as if to fan them. The box is not opened at this point and the hole is toward the back. The box is put on the stage and opened up so that it's backside is touching the edge of the larger box. It is at that point that the assistant crawls from behind the big box through the hole and into the smaller box as in our illustration below.



Once the girl is in the box the larger box is lifted and displayed in a similar manner. It is then opened up and nested over the smaller box. Once it is down on the ground both boxes are rotated to show all sides, being careful to not raise them and show the hidden assistant. At this point you make a magical gesture, your assistant stands and she is lifted out of the two boxes to take her bows.

As mentioned this illusion is the genius of U.F. Gen. Grant, it's very effective, easy to build and requires a minimum amount of rehearsal.



IN AND OUT BOXES

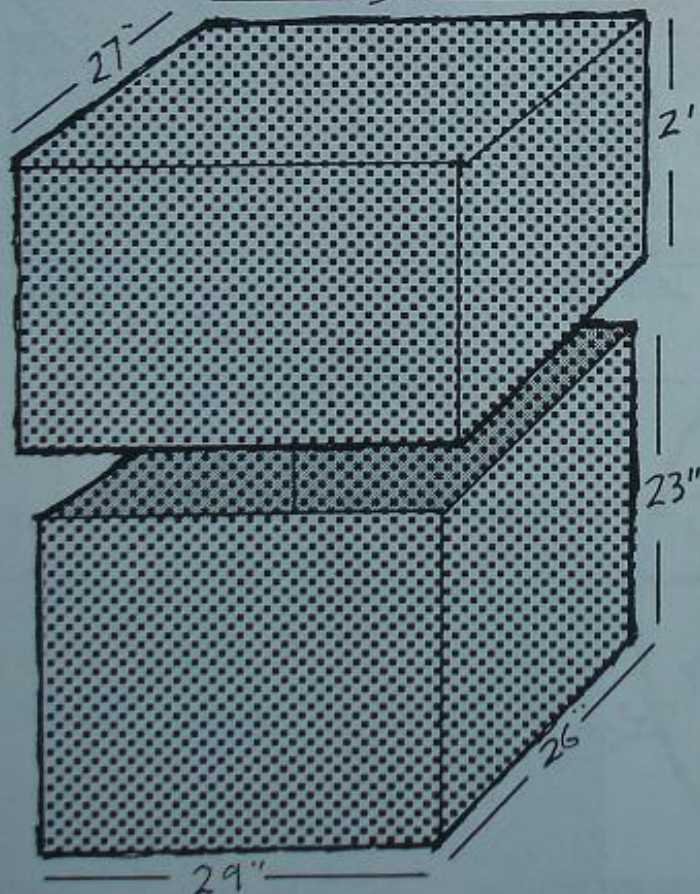
A large red box is brought out and the magician tells the audience that they are going to help him perform this illusion. That said, a large banner that has the instructions printed on it is brought out for the audience to read along with the magician. The banner says:

- STEP 1. Open the red box.
- STEP 2. Remove the yellow box.
- STEP 3. Open the yellow box.
- STEP 4. Close the red box.
- STEP 5. Put the red box in the yellow box.
- STEP 6. Open the yellow box.
- STEP 7. Remove the red box.
- STEP 8. Open the red box.

THIS TRICK IS SO SIMPLE IT CAN BE DONE BY CHILDREN

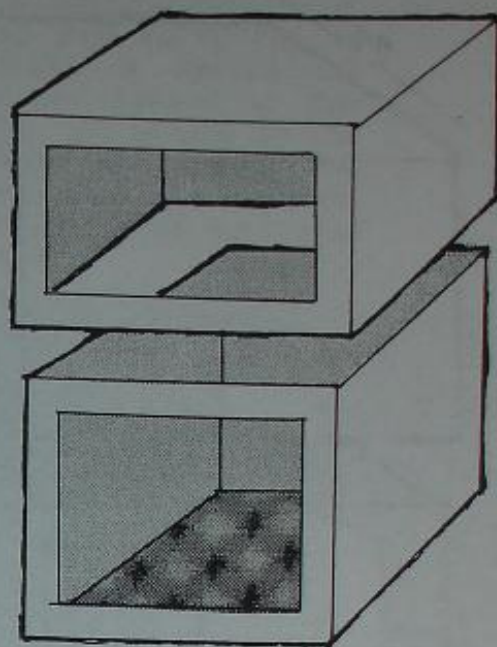
The instructions are followed to the puzzelment of the audience and magician alike. As a finale, with both boxes sitting open on stage, the magician reads the final sentence "This trick is so simple it can be done by children"-and from each box up pops a child!

The first part of making this illusion a reality is to find two kids. Once done, the rest is all measurements based on those kids. Obviously, the smaller the boxes, the better the illusion and the easier the handling. To the left we have given you some basic measurements that can be scaled up or down, depending on the size of the children. The large banner or poster pays a major part in the effect as well.



The back of the boxes have holes cut in them so that once the nesting aspect is done the boxes are placed as in our bottom drawing, near the banner so that the children come through the back curtain, behind the banner then into the back of the boxes.

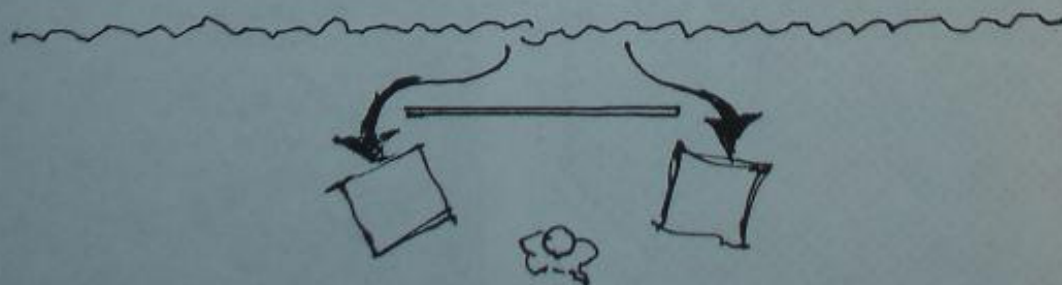
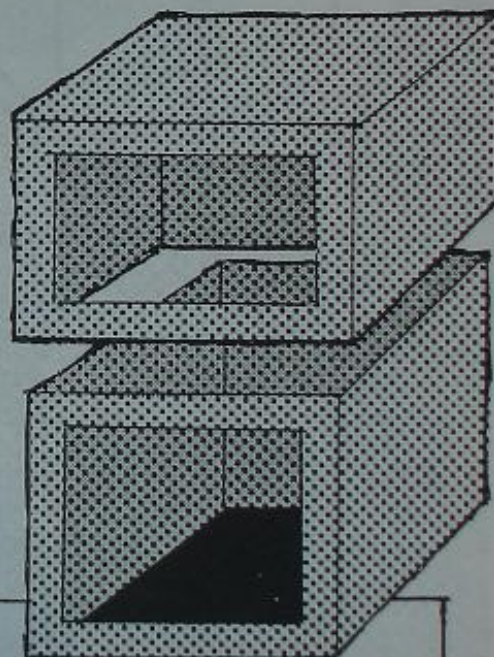
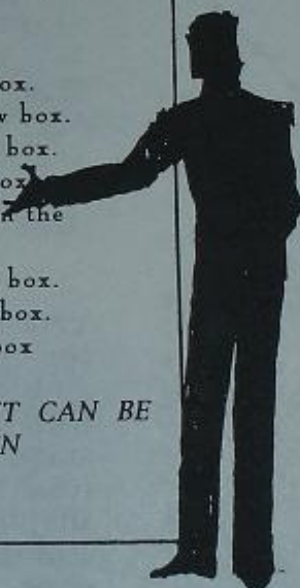
The banner could be made from wood or foamcore, or it could be a cloth banner that sets up on a tripod. A signpainter or sign company can do the lettering.



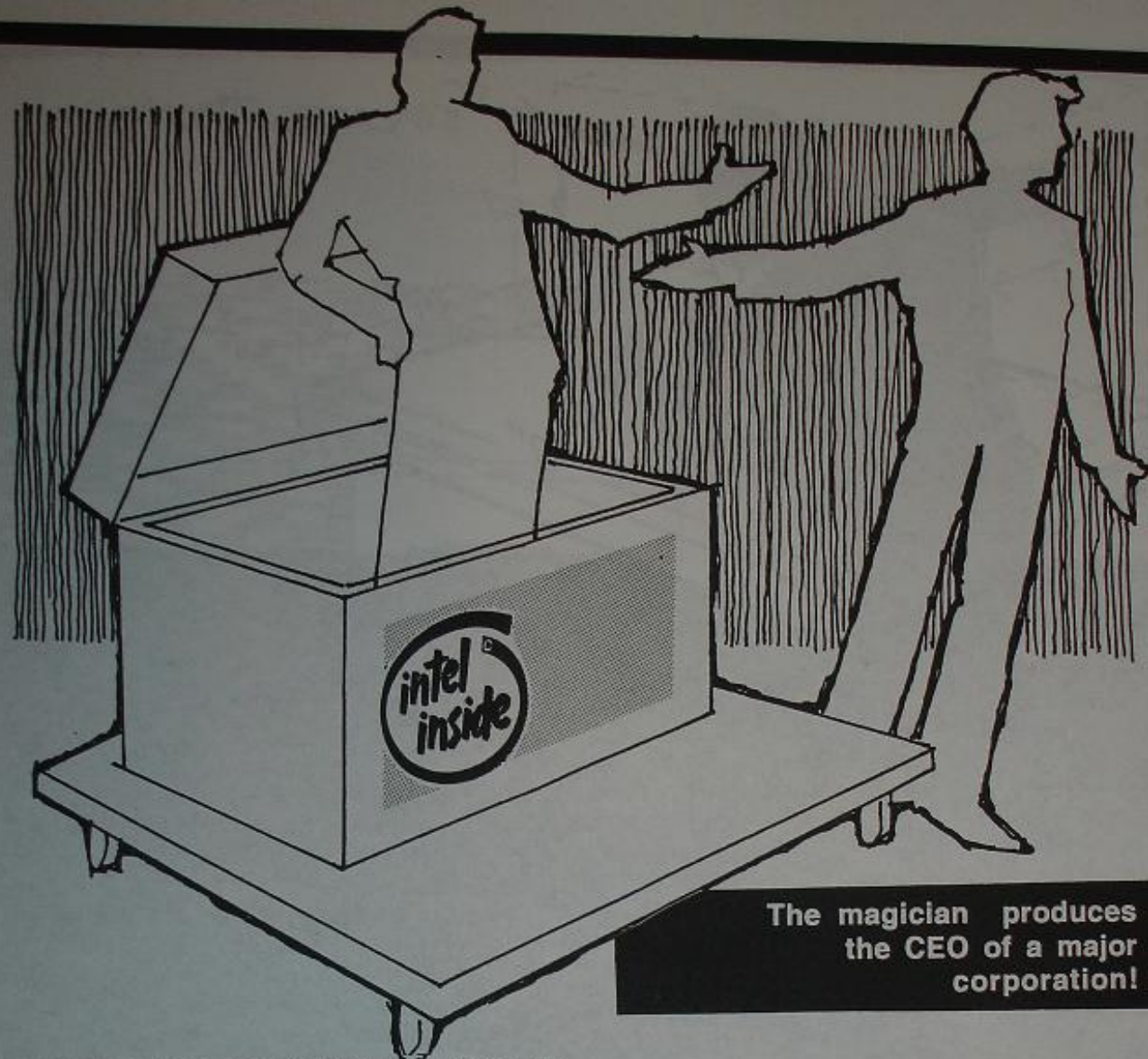
THE DOUBLE BOX MYSTERY

- STEP 1. Open the red box.
- STEP 2. Remove the yellow box.
- STEP 3. Open the yellow box.
- STEP 4. Close the red box.
- STEP 5. Put the red box in the yellow box.
- STEP 6. Open the yellow box.
- STEP 7. Remove the red box.
- STEP 8. Open the red box.

THIS TRICK IS SO SIMPLE IT CAN BE DONE BY CHILDREN



PLAN VIEW SHOWING THE CHILDREN COMING THROUGH THE BACK CURTAIN AND INTO THE BACK OF THE BOXES.

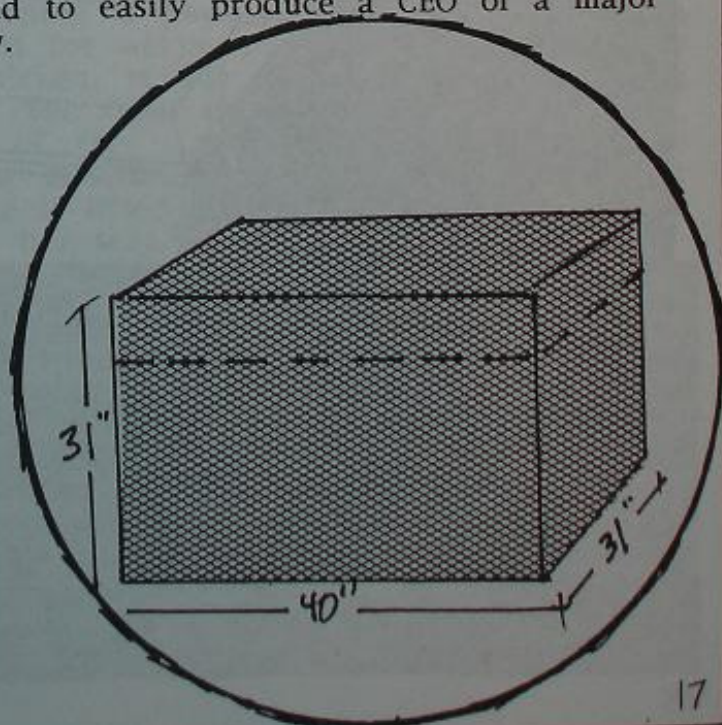


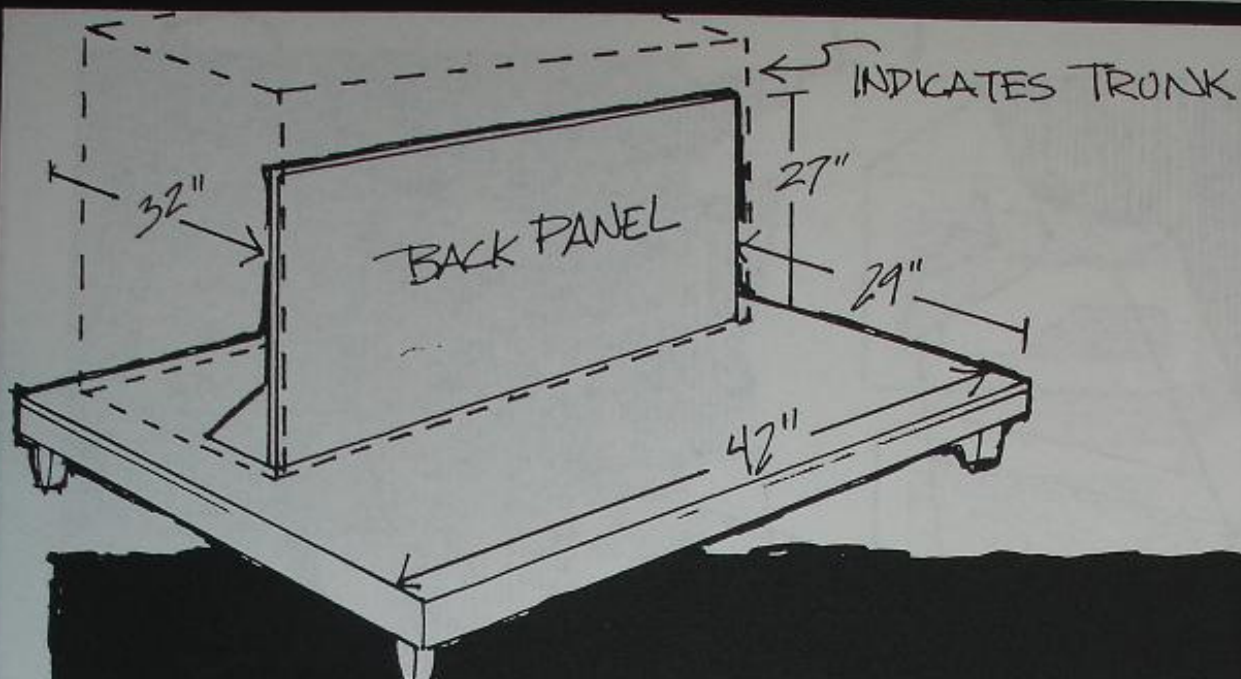
The magician produces the CEO of a major corporation!

FAST MAKE TIP OVER

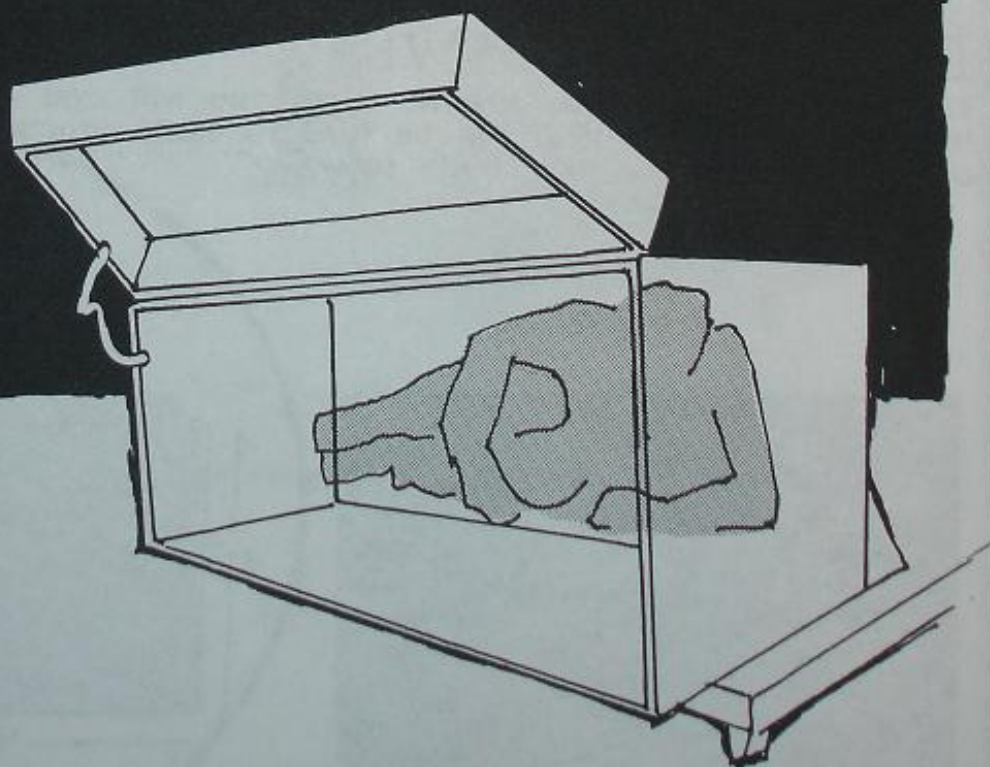
This is one of the most versatile props you will ever own. It's great as an illusion all by itself or it can be used to easily produce a CEO of a major corporation for your next trade show.

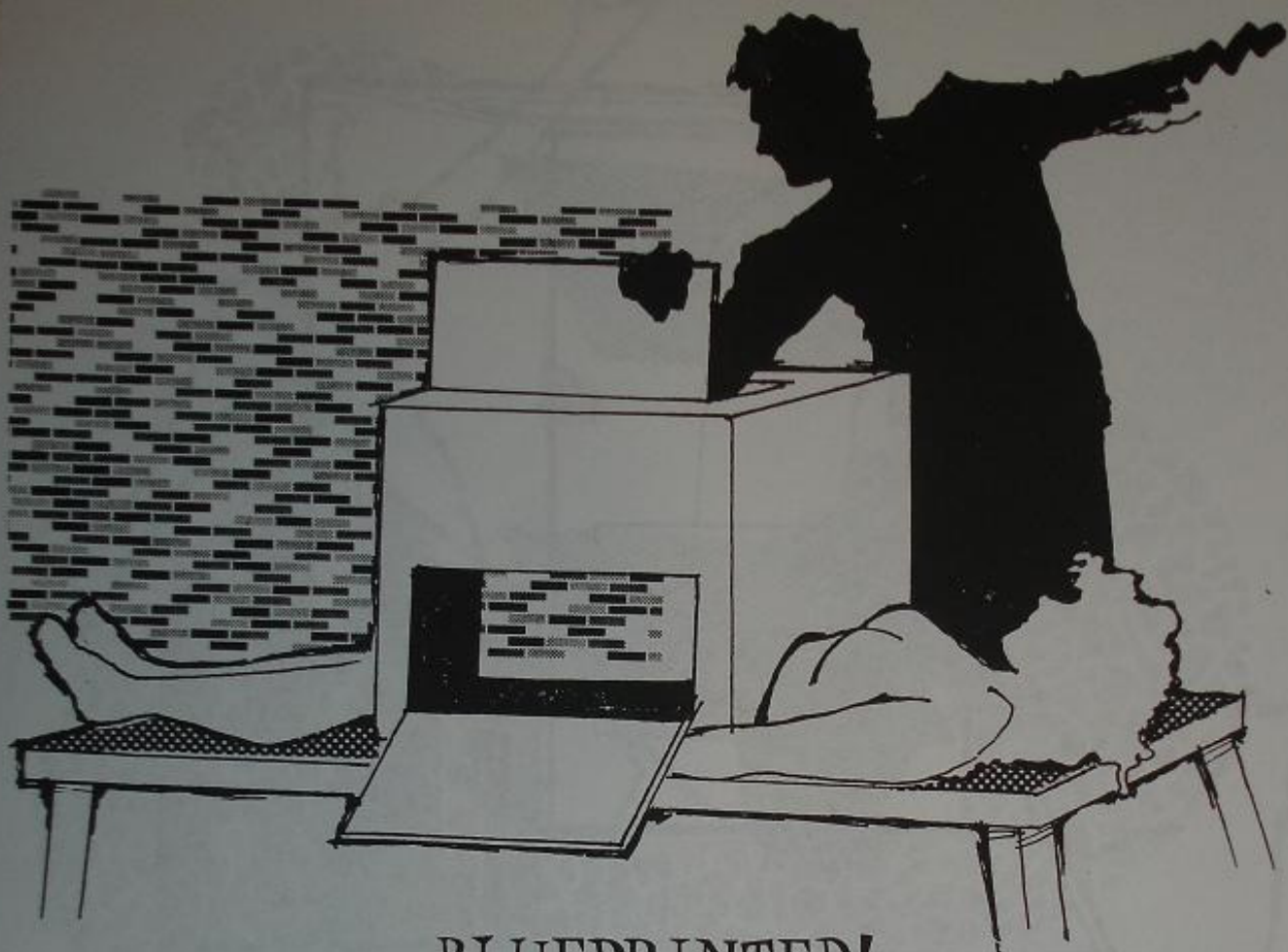
The quickest way to make the trunk itself is to fabricate a box with no bottom. The box should be made from 1/2 ply screwed and glued together. The five sides should be made to be 37" tall, 40" wide and 28" deep. Once the box is made, use a hand saw to cut down 4" from the top all the way around. This will make the chest and the lid will fit perfectly!





The tip over trunk is really a simple principle once you understand the trunk has no bottom. The bottom is replaced by the back panel as shown in our upper drawing. This piece is bolted to the base and always stays stationary as the trunk tips in front of it. The trunk has hinges that allows it to be tipped forward, a strap that keeps the top as you want it and a "bumper" on the front that keeps the trunk at least 1" off the base to protect the front and make it easy for you to pull the trunk up again. What makes this a great prop to produce your CEO is that all he has to do is crouch down and then stand up! BINGO he is a genius because of you!



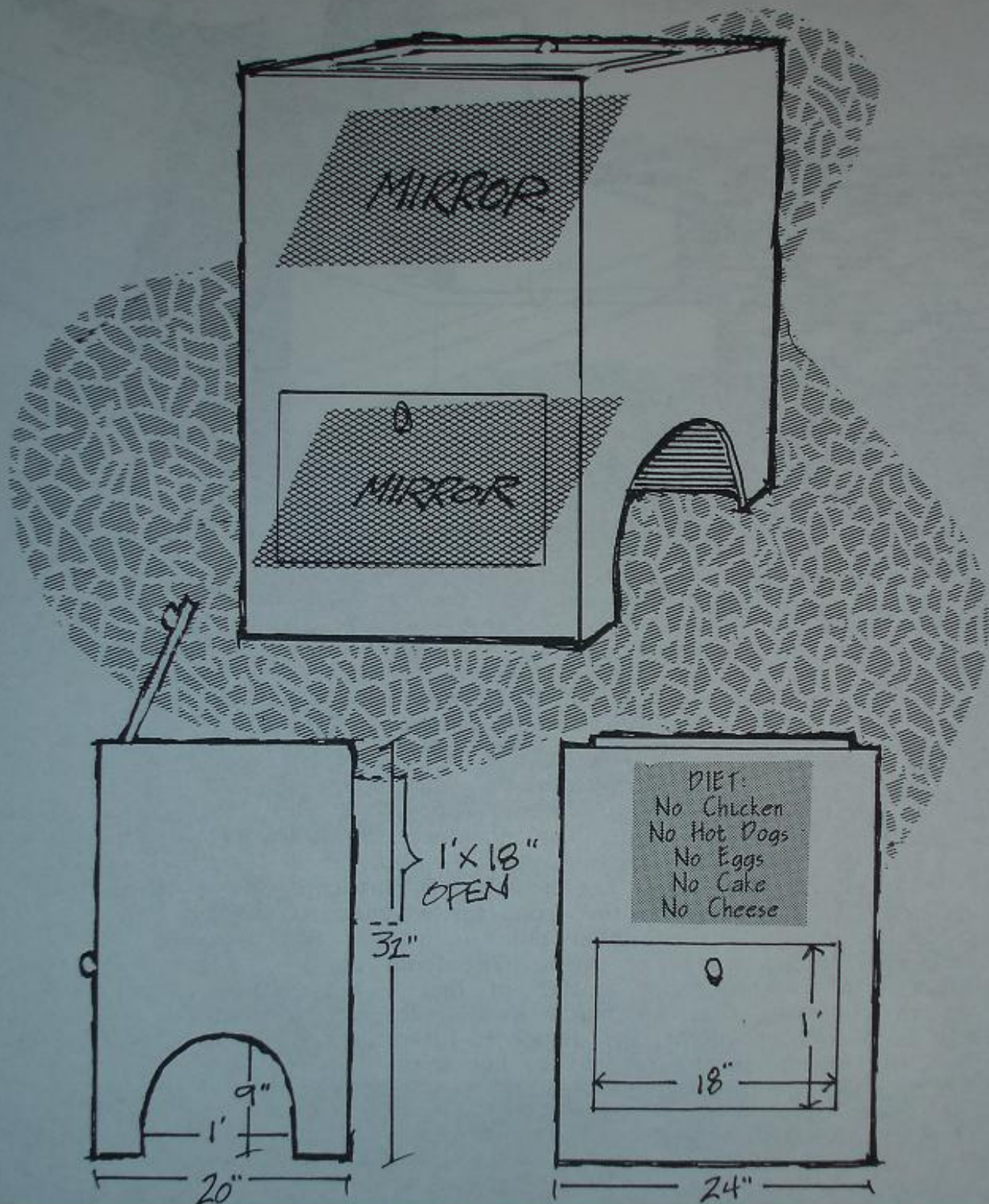


BLUEPRINTED!

The combination of Richard Simmon's "Deal a Meal" and a Bamberg illusion is somewhat unlikely, but guess what? The magician announces that he has invented a weight loss machine. It will work on anybody that wants to lose a few pounds. An audience volunteer is selected and asked to lay down on a small table. The machine is put over her and the magician points out the blueprint on the front for weight loss. He opens a top door and begins to remove, a rubber chicken, rubber hot dogs, several eggs, a rubber cake and a wedge of cheese. The front door is opened and she has, in fact, lost weight. As a matter of fact - her middle is missing. The magician confesses that he made a mistake and the young lady doesn't really need to lose weight. His device is lifted off of her and she is given a bucket of chicken as she returns to her seat.

This prop is basically a box made to the dimensions on our next page. The box can be made from cardboard and, frankly, I think the shabbier the prop in this instance, the better. It can also be made from 1/4" plywood and finished out nicely. This is your choice. The table she rests on can be a standard folding table, or constructed for the prop. Again, your choice.

The box itself is the focus of the illusion. How it is fabricated is up to you. Following the dimensions on the next page, you will see that it incorporates the periscope method of double mirrors. If you go the cardboard method of construction, then 1/4" plexiglass mirrors are the best way of going, although they will work well for the wood box as well. They need to be positioned as indicated at 45 degrees each. The front door is as drawn and the top door is there to pull out the funny weight loss items stored behind the top mirror.



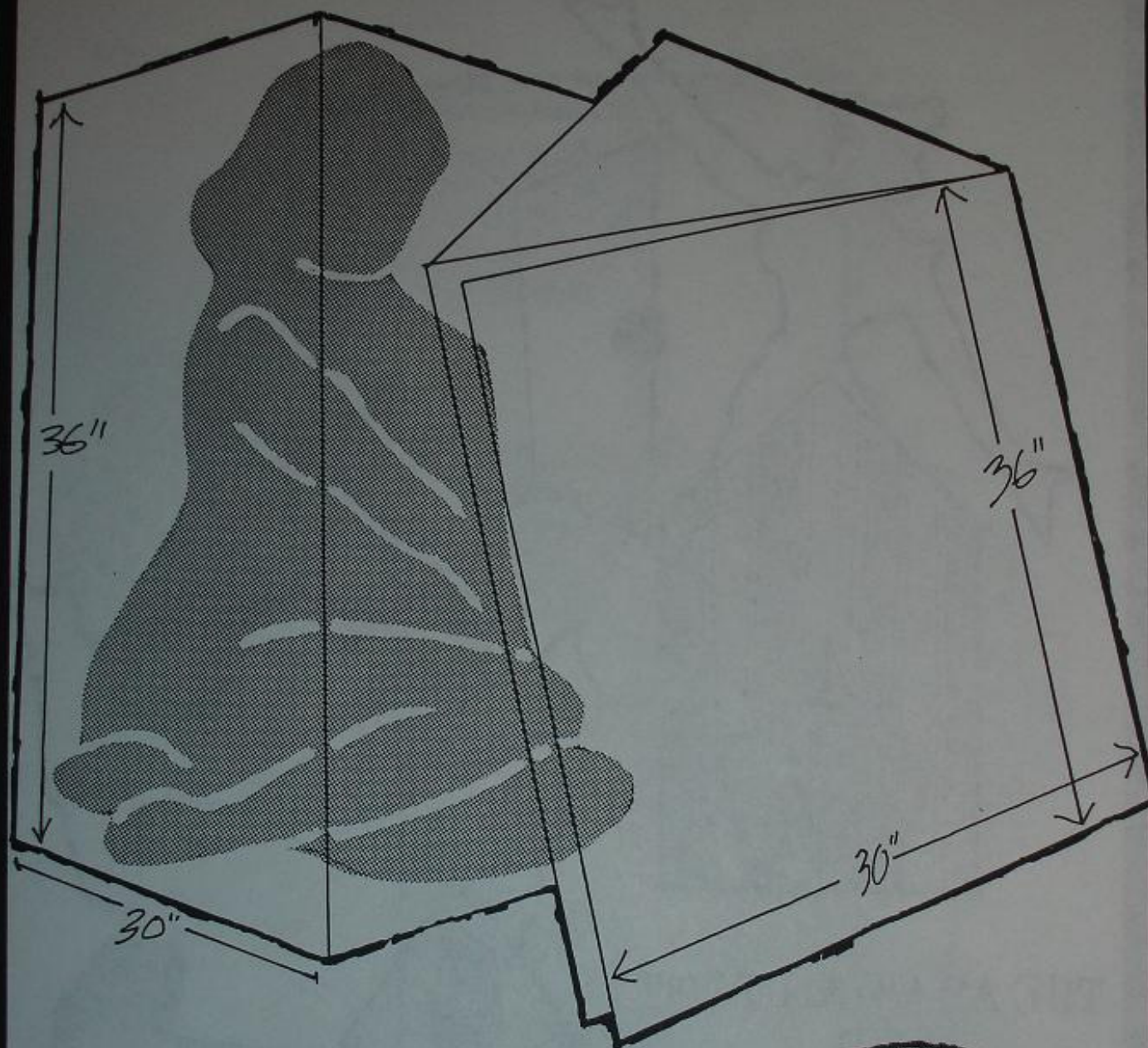
The above drawings pretty much tell the story. When the front door is opened, the audience's view hits the bottom mirror, reflects to the top mirror and out the back 1'x18" opening, giving the illusion that her body is missing. The bottom mirror surface faces the audience. The top mirror surface faces the back top opening. Make sure that whatever is behind the prop is of a vertical nature because the image seen through the front door is actually above what it should be. The magician can quickly walk behind the prop if his coat and pants are of the same basic color.



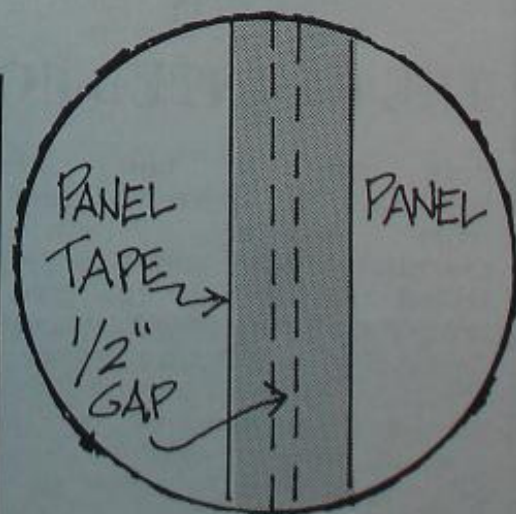
THE ARABIAN TENT AND THE HAUNTED HOUSE

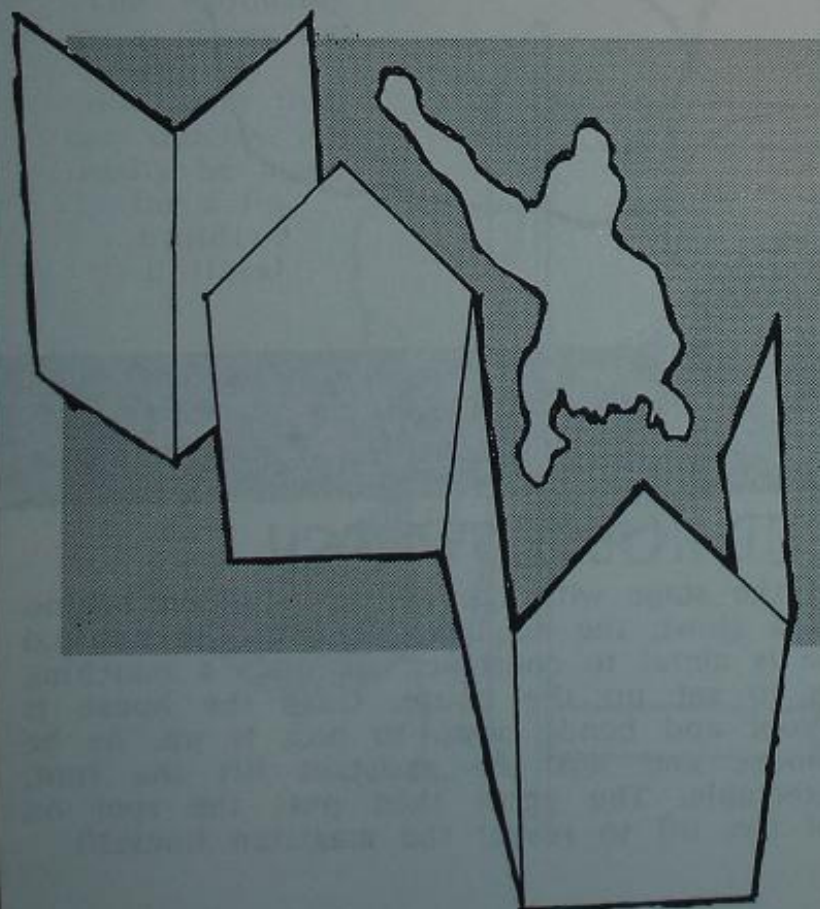
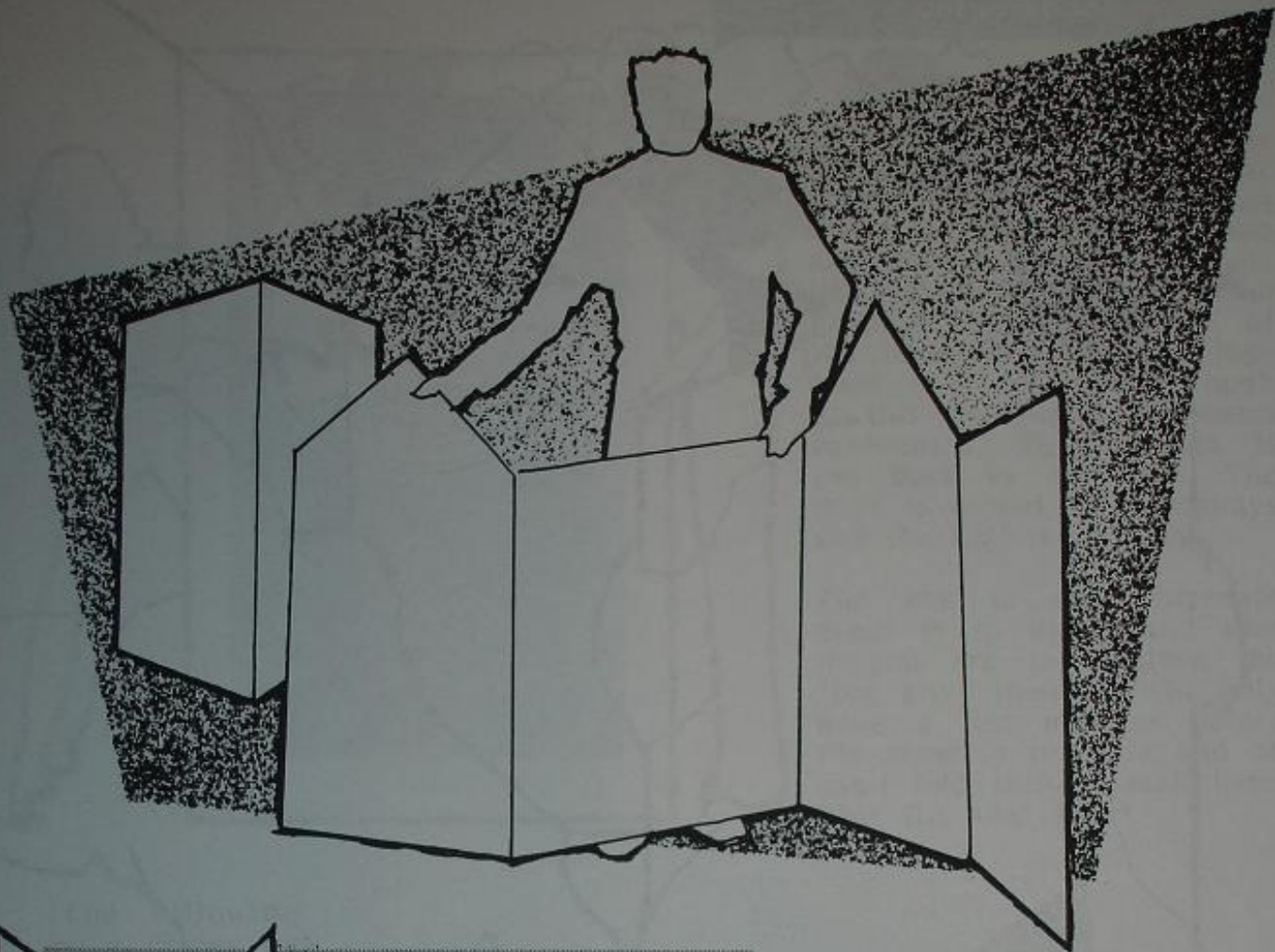
Both easy to build illusions produce a person, seemingly from nowhere. Both are essentially the same prop, just styled differently to give two separate themes. Neither is a new idea but both are excellent for the performer who needs a fast and inexpensive solution to a production. The Haunted House actually allows for a switch that is mind boggling!



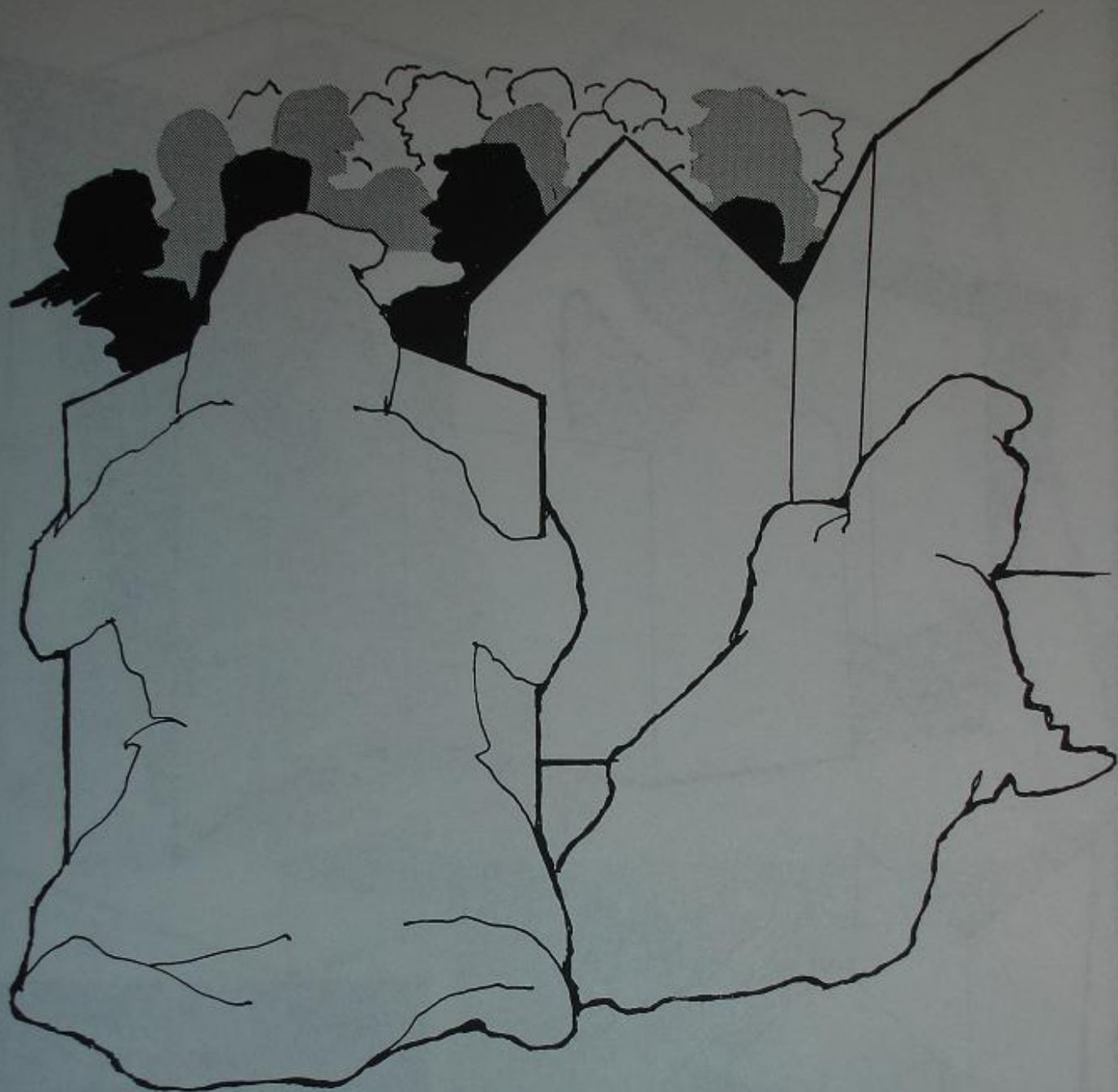


Both props feature the same method with the girl hidden behind the folded roof piece prior to the illusion being set up. This may be one of the most practical illusions ever invented. It plays big and can be simply made out of cardboard or foamcore. All four sides should be cut out separately then hinged together with tape the same color as the selected board. In the case of the Haunted House the typical brown cardboard can be used. For the Arabian tent you might want to consider a white foamcore board. When the four sides are taped together allow about a $1/2$ " space of tape only, as shown to the right. This forms a tape hinge that will allow the folding of the sides to be much easier. The roof segments should also be cut in two sections and taped with tape to allow a flexible fold





As in our top drawing, the magician begins to unfold the house, showing all sides. The house is then momentarily positioned in front of the roof which allows a few seconds for the assistant to crawl within the house as shown in our sketch to the left. Once done, the back is folded in and around the assistant. The roof is then shown on all sides and placed on top of the house. The rest is all presentation!



The Haunted House version of this illusion lends itself to many unusual presentation possibilities. In our drawing above, showing a backstage view, we are showing a switch that can take place that adds greatly to the mystery of the illusion.

THE HAUNTED HOUSE SWITCH

As the house sits to the side of the stage with the assistant hidden behind the roof costumed in a sheet as a ghost, the magician explains the unusual properties of this small house he is about to construct. He dons a matching ghost costume sheet and begins to set up the house. Once the house is positioned, he goes behind the roof and bends down to pick it up. As he does so, he crawls into the house and lets the assistant lift the roof, making the switch almost undetectable. The ghost then puts the roof on the house, gestures and the roof flies off to reveal the magician himself!

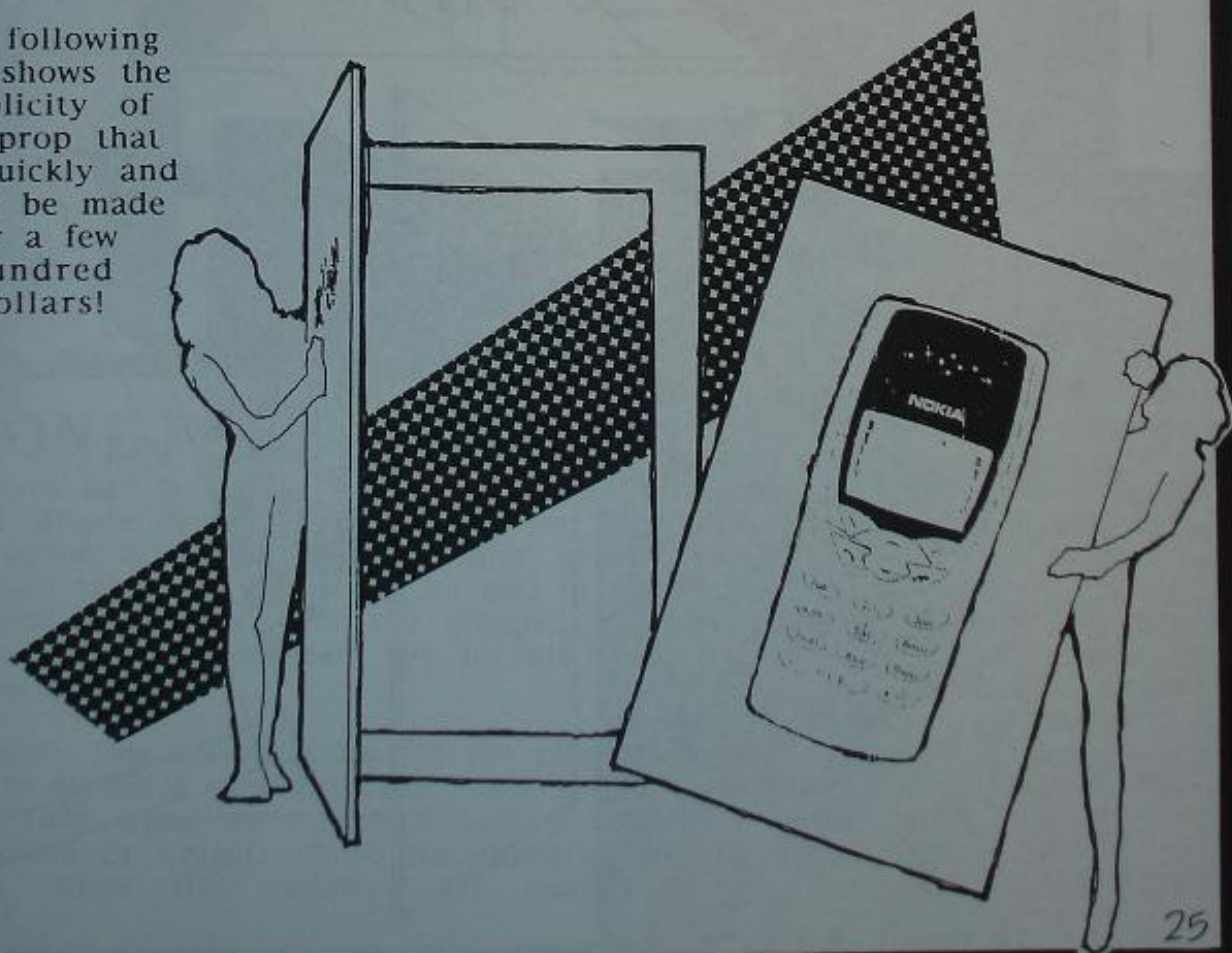
The Magician produces
the CEO of a major
corporation!

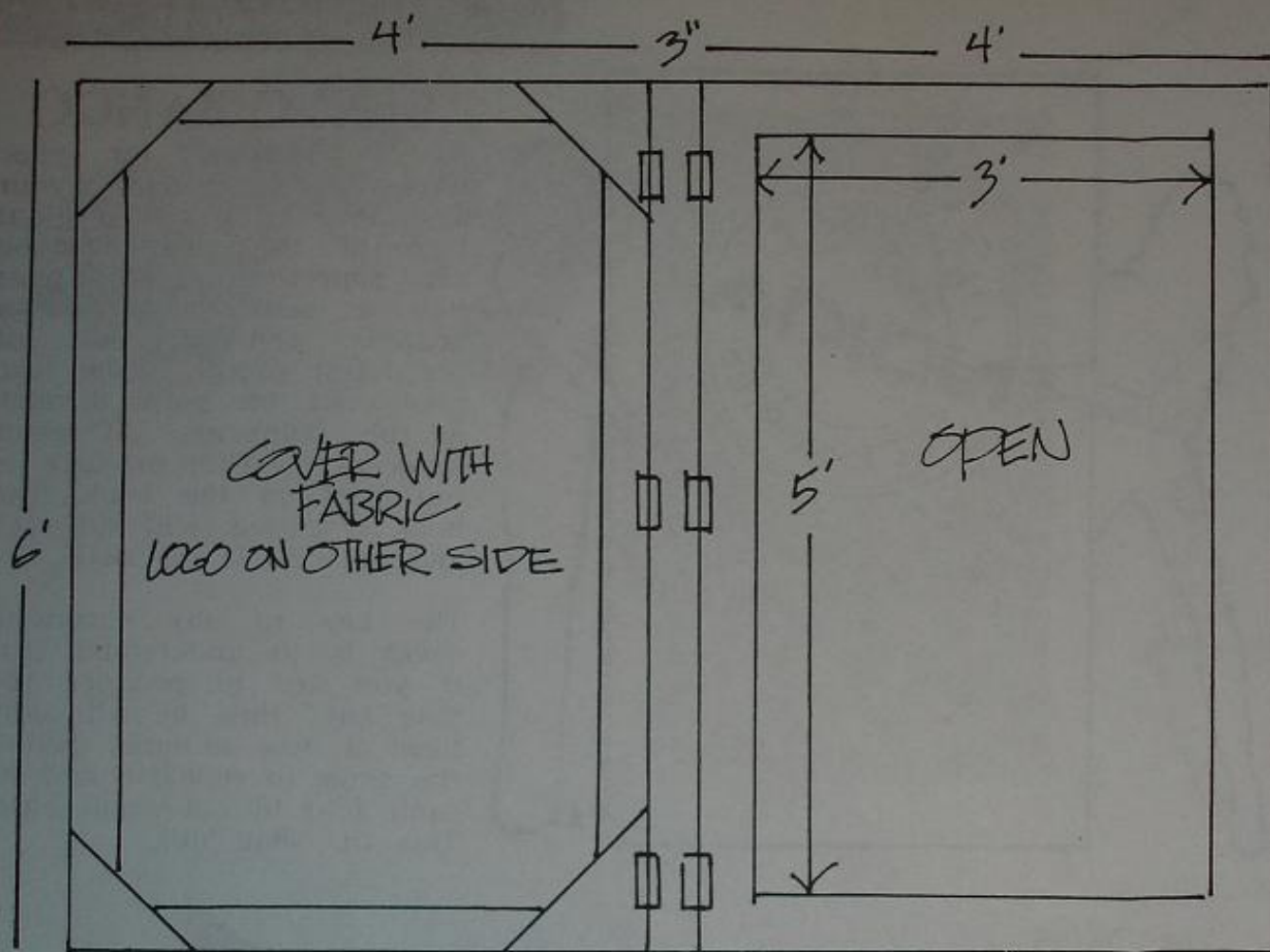
BINGO BANGO

As an opening for your next corporate event your assistants bring out a giant logo of the company you are representing. It opens like a book to reveal a graphic representation of the latest product. The logo book can be seen through at this point and all seems innocent. The product is put back in the book. The book is closed, slid sideways and the CEO is revealed!

The key to any corporate event is to understand that if you are to produce the "big guy" then he will only have a few minutes before the show to rehearse and he can't fold into a small base. This fits that bill.

The following
page shows the
simplicity of
this prop that
can quickly and
easily be made
for a few
hundred
dollars!



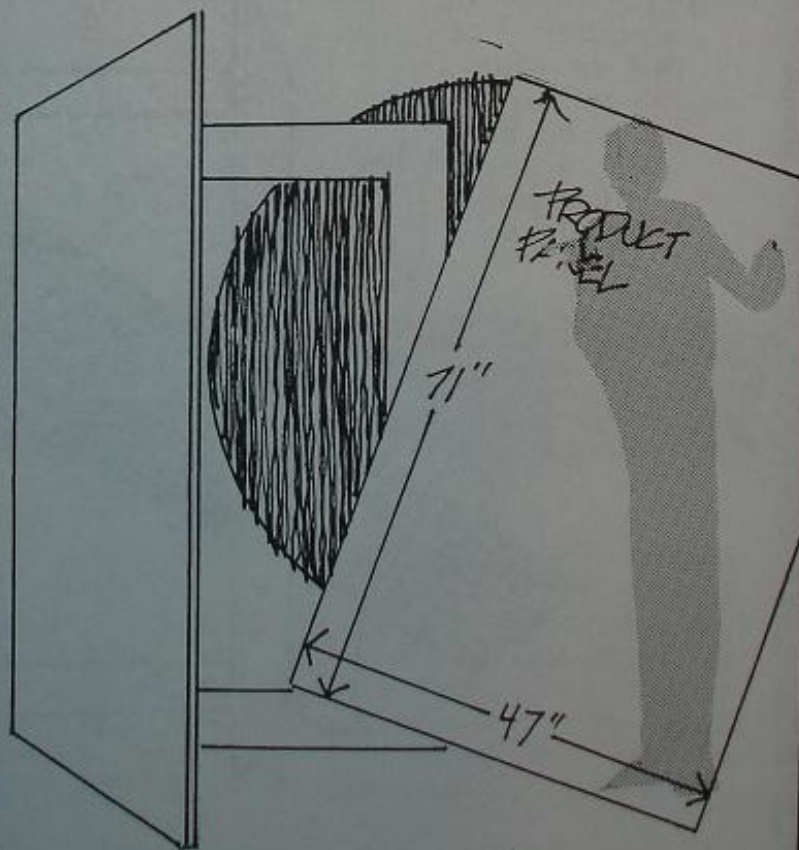


FRONT ELEVATION

The initial prop is a two fold screen with the front being a scenic flat constructed out of 1x2 with corner supports and a muslin skin. On the front it is painted with the logo of the company to be represented. The back is painted in a flat black. The 3" panel allows space for the product panel.

The second panel is made from 3/4" ply cut out to allow a view through. The product panel is 47"x71" tall and painted with an image of the product to be promoted. This panel, too is fabricated with standard scenic construction methods, and painted black on the back.

As shown, the company executive first hides behind the entire unit, then moves behind the product panel, then back again, to be produced out of the entire prop!





SOMEONE FROM NOWHERE

Several years ago a Dallas magician named North Bigbee came up with a unique and simple vanish of a girl. He set up a black backdrop and rolled it out to cover the floor to show that no traps were involved. Next, he opened a card table and set it up on and in front of the backdrop. A young lady was next introduced and she stepped up on the table. North took a cloth on a dowel and covered her up momentarily. He dropped the cloth and she was gone!

Two problems: One was that he did the effect in front of magicians who all knew it was a black art principle and the other problem inherent with vanishes is that when an audience sees a vanish, the challenge is set to find the person or object. With an appearance a magician has the surprise element to throw the audience off guard. So I made the idea an appearance.



All you need for this effect is a banner 3 to 4 feet wide by about 4' long, a table and a black backdrop. The table is rigged with matching black fabric that is rolled up on the backside of the table. It is stapled at the top and held in place by a bulldog clip.

In performance, first the backdrop is set up and rolled out on the floor. Next, the table is set up, and the magician walks behind it to demonstrate it is a normal table.

Once done he hits the bulldog clip at the same time his assistant brings out the banner. The cloth drops as the audience is distracted by the banner. The girl comes from behind the cloth to behind the table black art. The magician shows the cloth, holds it up, the girl climbs on to the table and TaaDaa!



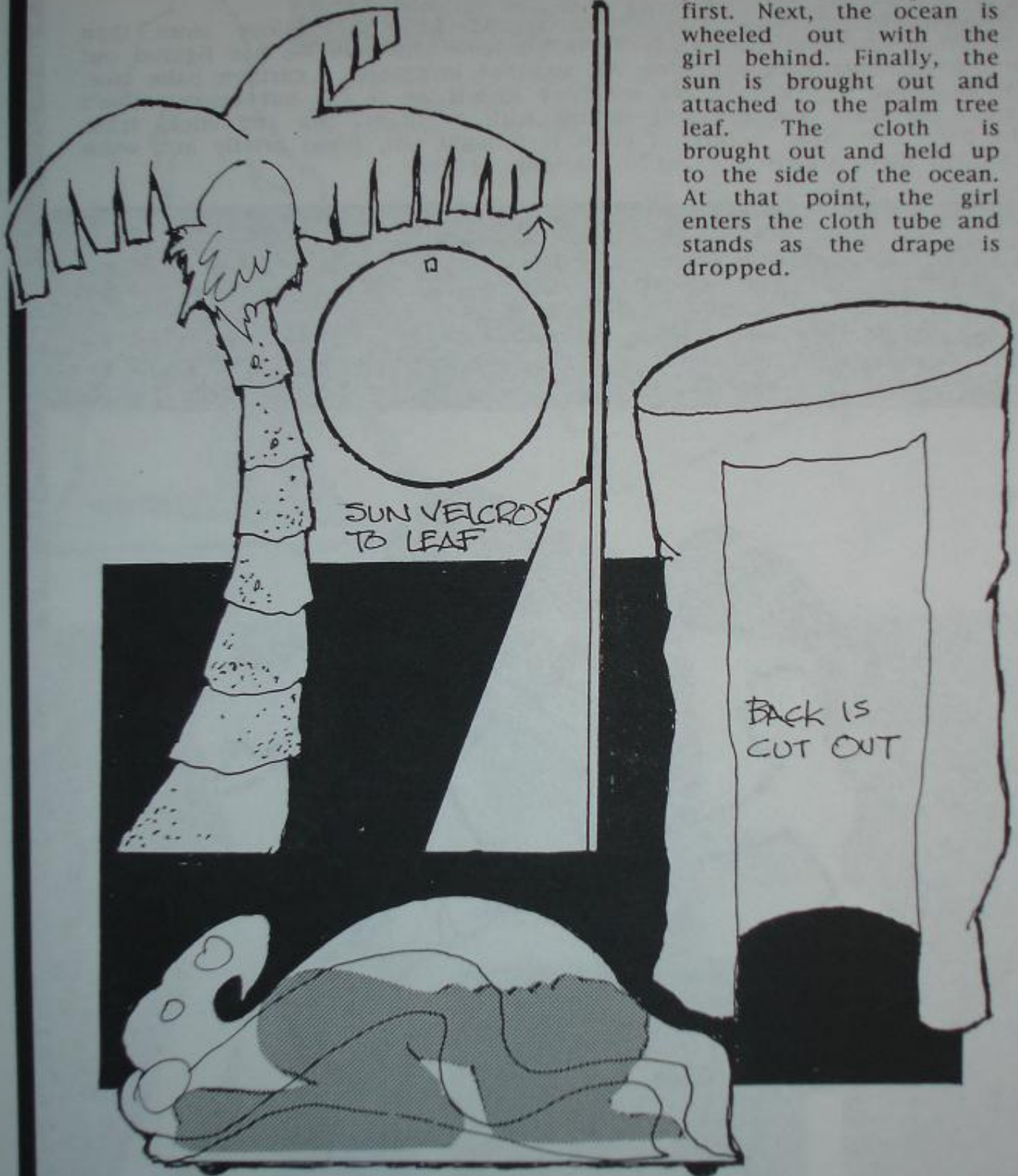
AT THE BEACH!

The magician explains that there is one thing he enjoys more than performing and that is a day at the beach. But now he has figured out how to combine both activities. An assistant brings on a cartoon palm tree. "What about the ocean?" The assistant wheels on a cut out ocean. "Don't forget the sun." The assistant returns with a cut-out sun and sticks it to the palm tree. Next, a tube of cloth is brought out, lifted briefly and when dropped there stands a beautiful bathing beauty!

All the props involved should be fun and cartoon looking. They can be easily made from mostly cardboard or 1/4" plywood. The "ocean" is a flat cut-out on a dolly that the girl is hidden behind. It is approximately 40" wide, 20" deep and the cut-out itself is 24" tall. The palm tree is about 6' tall and has a brace behind it to allow it to stay upright. The sun is stuck onto the palm tree leaf with velcro. The cloth is a hula hoop with 6' of fabric attached. It is opened at the back as per our sketch on the next page.



In performance, the palm tree is brought out first. Next, the ocean is wheeled out with the girl behind. Finally, the sun is brought out and attached to the palm tree leaf. The cloth is brought out and held up to the side of the ocean. At that point, the girl enters the cloth tube and stands as the drape is dropped.



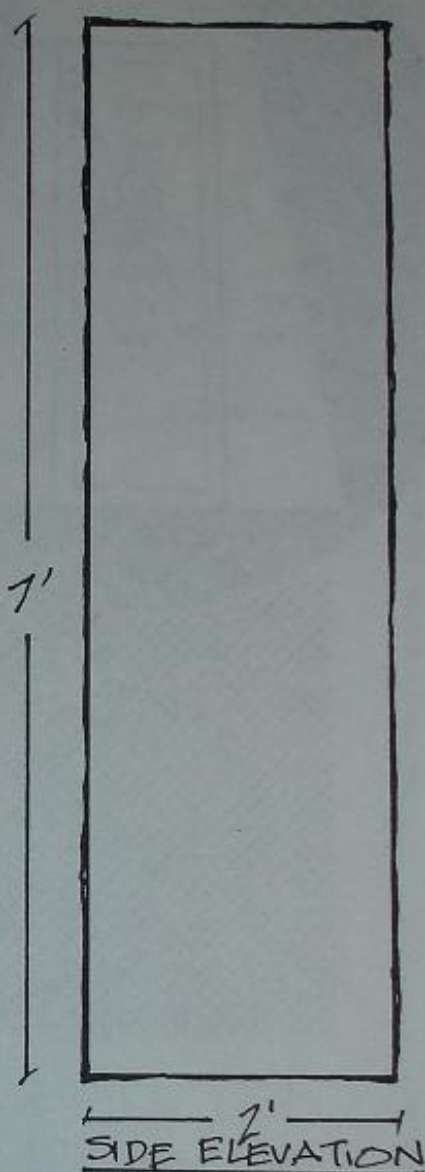
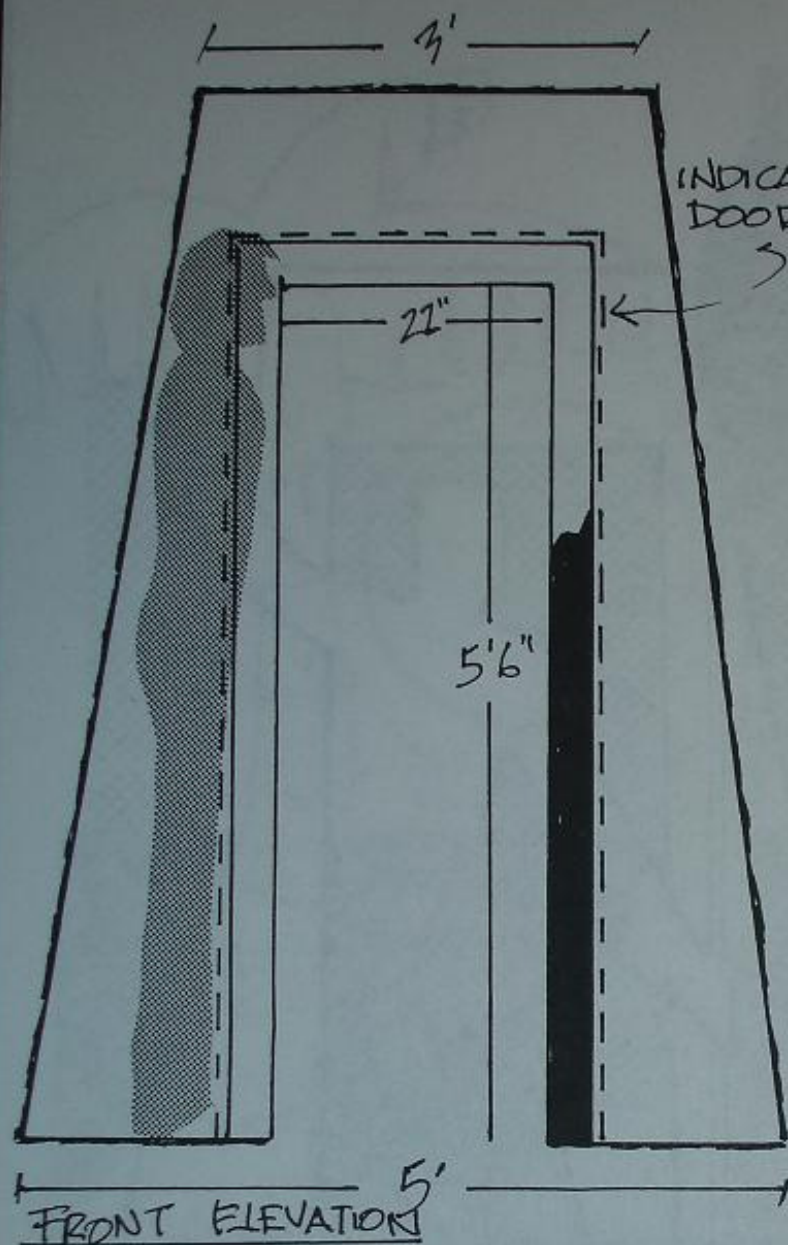
OCEAN WITH GIRL BEHIND



THE SHADOW OF LIFE

On the stage sets an oddly shaped frame. Assistants enter and open the door to show the unit empty. The door is shut and slowly a shadow is seen to form on the door. The shadow begins to take shape and it is seen to be the image of a man. Suddenly, the front door flies open and it's the magician!

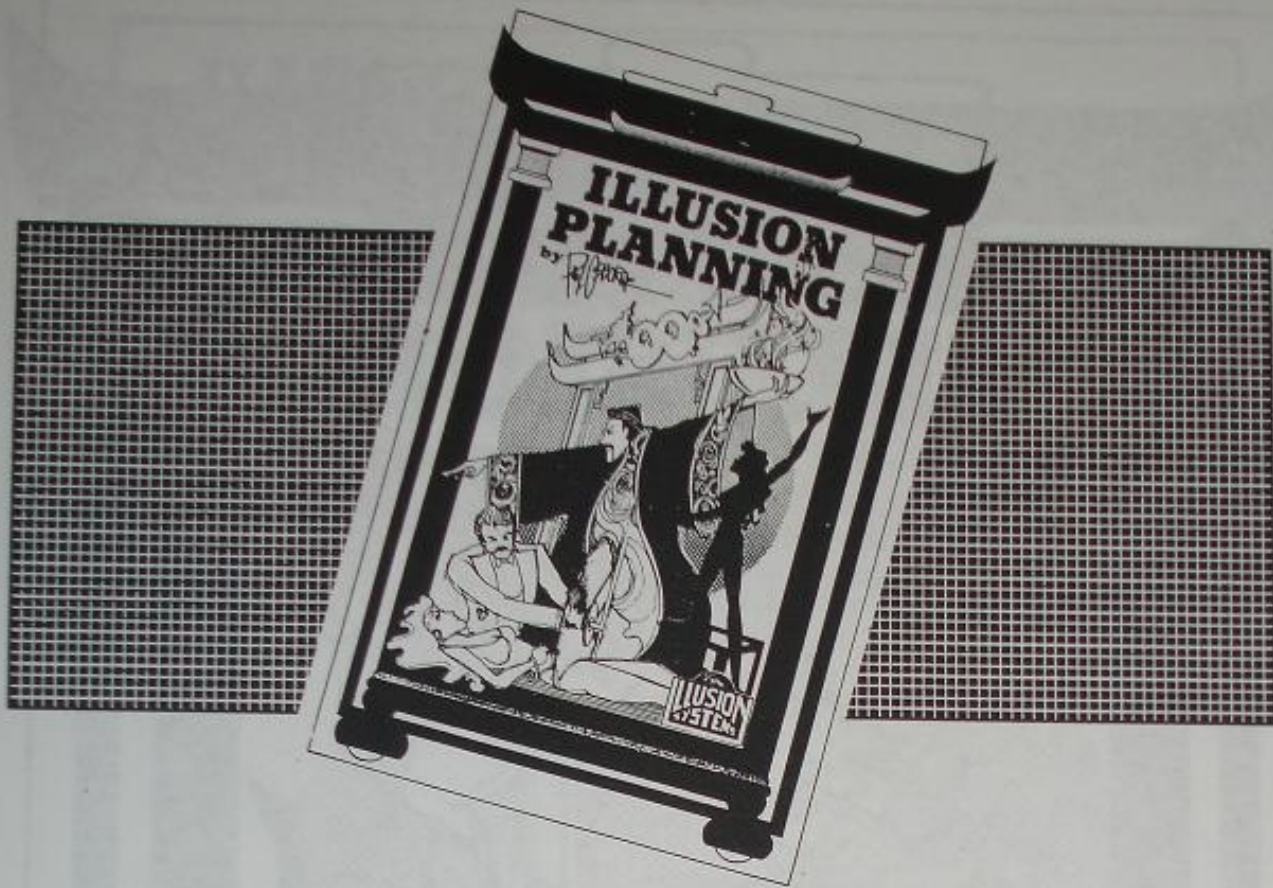
The framework is made to the dimensions on the next page. You will notice that the magician is hidden in the left panel. The area by his head needs to have a $8 \frac{1}{2}$ " clearance. In our drawing the door is omitted but the dotted lines indicate its placement over the black inner trim. The door is a 2" frame with either butcher paper or milk plex attached behind.



In performance the unit sits on stage with the magician hidden inside. Assistants come out, open the door, walk through the prop and position a photographer's light on a tripod behind the illusion. When the door is shut, the light shows through the front door. Once the door is shut, the magician moves behind the light and begins to make shadows with his hands. Finally, stepping in front of the light and walking forward. This action creates the image of a shadow form coming to life. He then opens the door and makes his appearance.



BACK VIEW



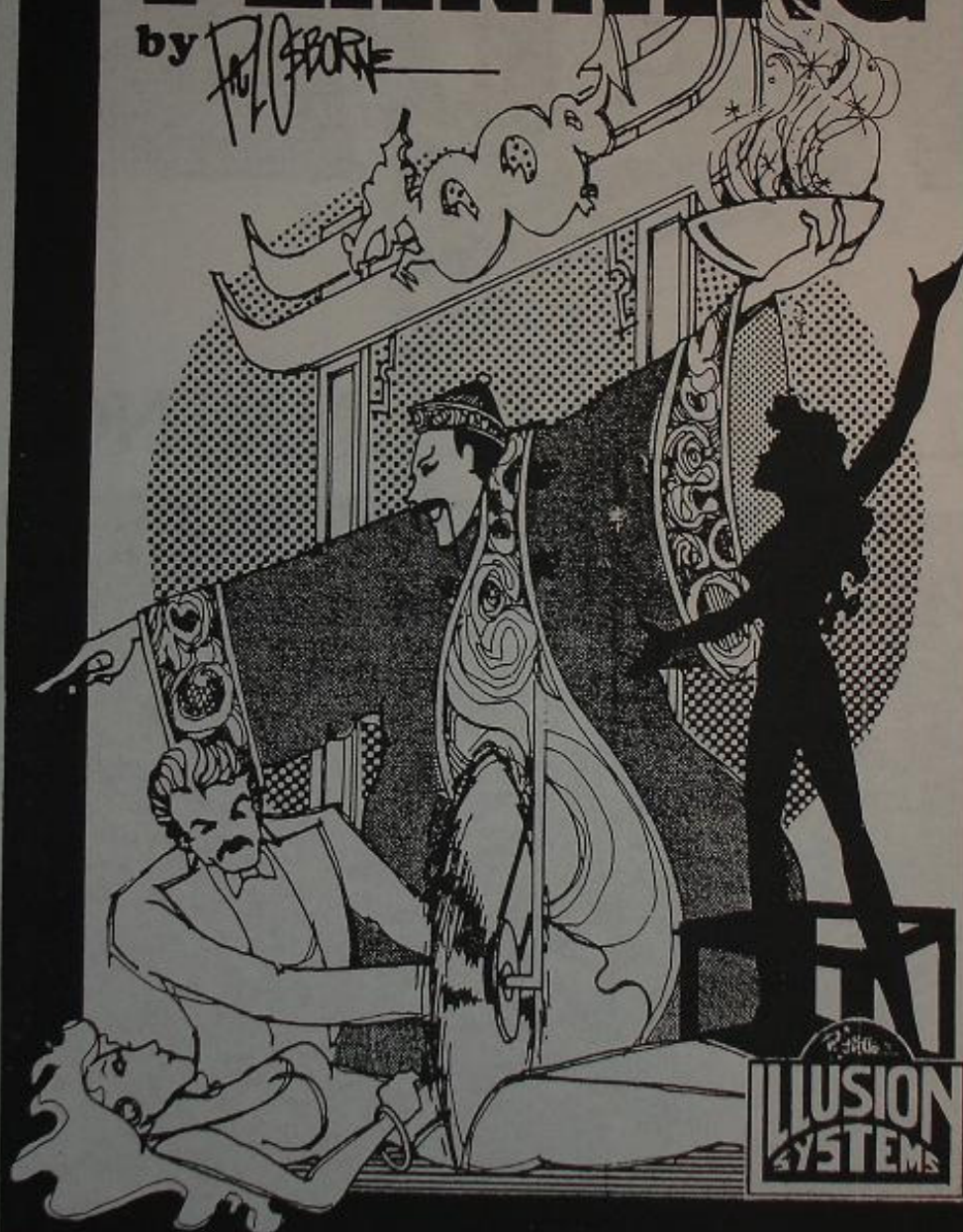
ILLUSION PLANNING

I wrote Illusion Planning in the early eighties based on the lessons the parks taught me about how the typical audience responds to a twenty minute illusion show. The illusion shows we provided theme parks were not acts like Marv and Carol Roy's Mr. Electric, but more along the lines of a scaled down illusion show as once presented by the great masters like Thurston, Dante and Blackstone. Naturally, the budget dictates the scope of the show, but the actual "meat" of the show was the illusions and how they were placed within the show. An obvious example being that you wouldn't want the magician to magically appear at the end of the show. With that thought in mind we paid careful attention to the flow of the show and what illusions seemed to fall in the proper slots to gain maximum audience attention. Another benefit from this book for many were the silhouettes I illustrated at the beginning of each chapter heading. I had many calls requesting permission to use the images on business cards, letterheads, etc. Of course, I would hope that you not copy the book and sell it, but I have no problem with magicians using those illustrations for their own promotion.

Although illusions have progressed in style, method and complexity as this book is being written, the same values and pacing can be seen in today's illusion stars' performances. In some cases you have to try the new illusion in different positions within your show, but hopefully this little book, long out of print, will form the basis of how you structure your illusion show.

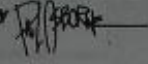
ILLUSION PLANNING

by *P. GEORGE*



ILLUSION
SYSTEMS

ILLUSION PLANNING

by 



ILLUSION
SYSTEM



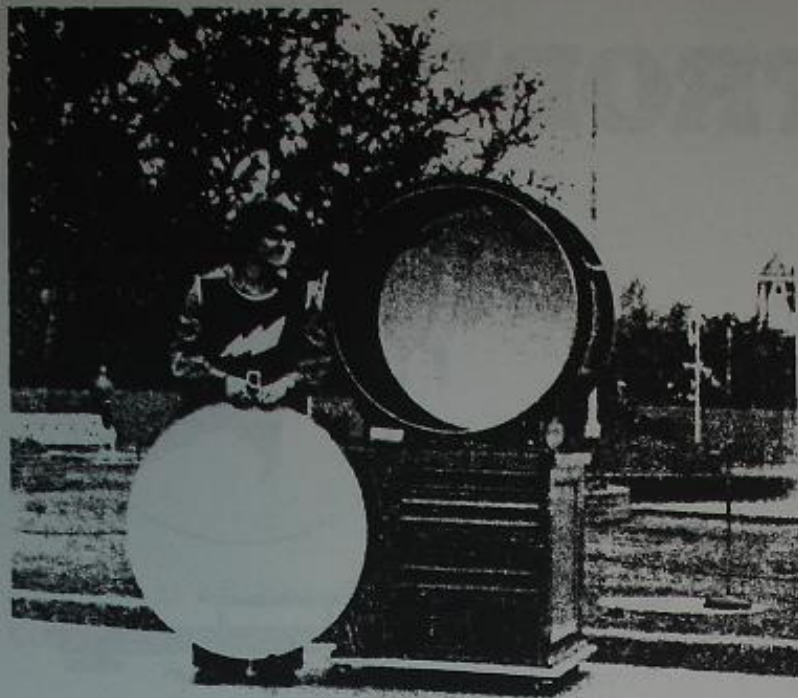
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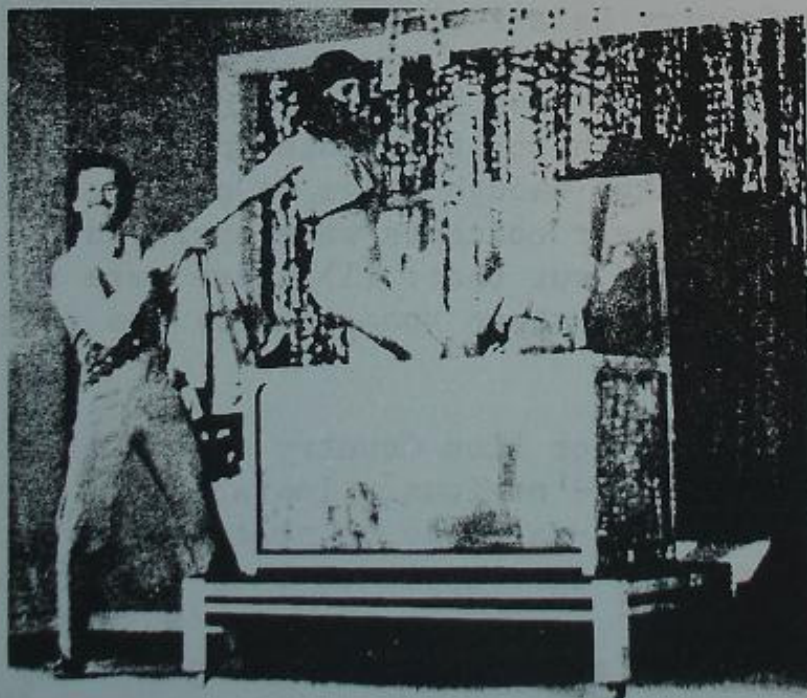
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Some illusions should be "flown" in the air to be effective, although the "Drum" illusion works well on it's base.



Another great classic illusion performed by our Cypress Gardens magician, Doug Anderson. Consider this prop as a great opener to introduce your assistant or, as Doug did it, your assistants.

INTRODUCTION



Illusion planning - what does that mean? "I saw Henning do this thing, see. I am going to do it in my school shows. It's this fountain, see...it spurts real water, see...and you put your girl on it and she floats up and...and..."

Believe it or not, I heard this very discussion. I also overheard two young "illusionists" planning a show for our local Lion Country Safari amusement park with, of course, the Girl to Lion illusion. Now they were assuming; (1) they could get a tame lion, (2) they had enough room back stage to load the critter into the illusion and, (3) they had a large enough stage to present the illusion properly. Once their concepts were approved by Lion Country, they found out that: (1) there were no tame lions, (2) there was no backstage room and (3) the stage was real small.

I got the contract for Lion Country that year and we didn't do the Girl to Lion - obviously impractical. Welcome to "Illusion Planning" - a guide to practicality, realism and sensibility and how they apply to you, the "miracle worker".

In my ads you have seen me say, "before you buy that plan, pay that carpenter, promise that client...wait!" My theory is that, as magicians we are dreamers, we are impractical and, of course, our goals are impossible, but now let's take a small book's worth to figure out how we, as magicians can - get real.

This, the smallest of the Illusion Systems family is dedicated to the smallest of the Osborne family -



Wiggle the Dog

Magic's Greatest Canine Fan



1st THOUGHTS

As you begin to consider mounting an illusion show or just adding an illusion to your already established act, the first thing you must do is research. Begin reading through your catalogues, view your video tapes, get as much input as you can on what type of illusion you want to add. Look at your existing act and analyze it to find what's missing. Should you add a production, a levitation, mutilation or a vanish? At what point do you perform this miracle in your act? Will the same illusion that works for Siegfried and Roy work for you? Research, study and look at what others are doing. See what audiences like and adapt it to your presentation and your style. You don't need to copy.

If you are going to totally re-do your act and upgrade to illusions, you have a lot of work ahead of you. Selecting the illusions that are not only practical, but that will also adapt to your style is most important. Selection of a "theme" or look is often the most difficult, yet it should be the easiest. It should simply reflect the performer. What do you want to do? What works for you? Although my upcoming chapter entitled "Know Thyself" deals with this in greater detail, here's a hint: David Copperfield would look totally out of place running around a Mismade Girl in tennis shoes with hair down to his shoulders, but this image is perfect for Doug Henning. You must define how your audience perceives you and capitalize on that personality - very difficult.

In building an illusion show or simply adding an illusion, it is most important that the flow work. Recently on the Tonight Show I saw a young, upcoming cabaret performer, Lance Burton. His act was brilliant, totally him, beautifully themed and a joy to watch. But, obviously he had just learned a Zombie routine because he stuck it

on the end of his normal act. Laymen friends told me, "Boy, he was great, but he should have stopped at..." Flow is most important. Of course, all of these elements must work in harmony in order for your act to succeed. Within the pages of this book I will try to hit the important points of illusion planning. This chapter's main point is to remind you to take time, be patient, research and mentally plan that illusion or illusion show before you blindly execute.

The research itself can be enjoyable. Remember, getting there is half the fun.

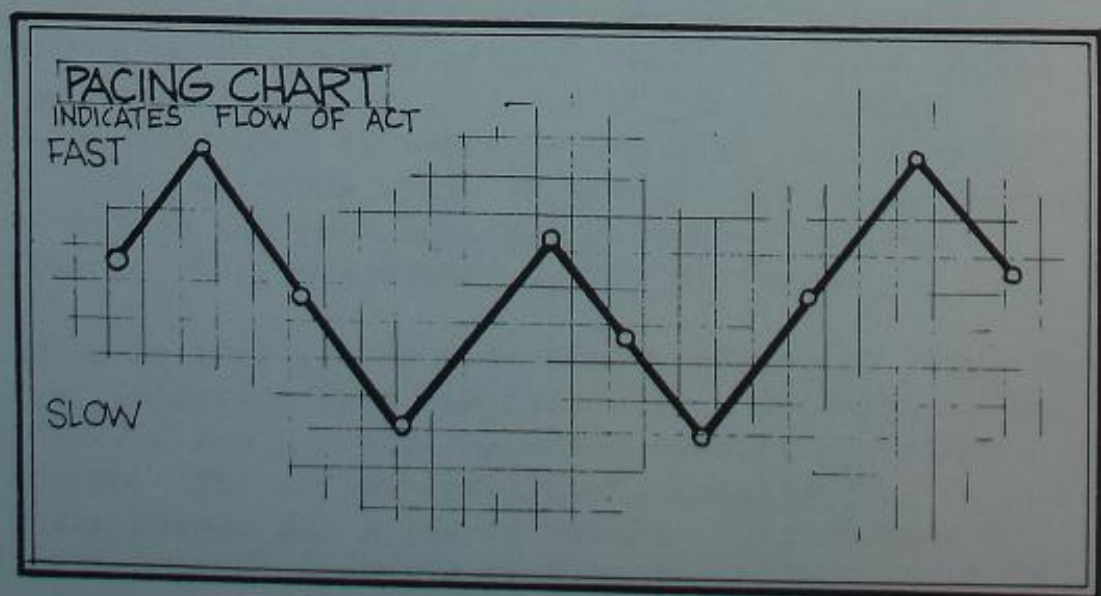


FLOW

As you plan your act, one of the most important aspects has to be the flow, or how your act is paced from one trick to another. This especially holds true in an illusion act because often you are locked into pre-recorded music and you can't speed up the pacing with your patter or presentation. So as you plan your illusion act, best you consider the flow first of all.

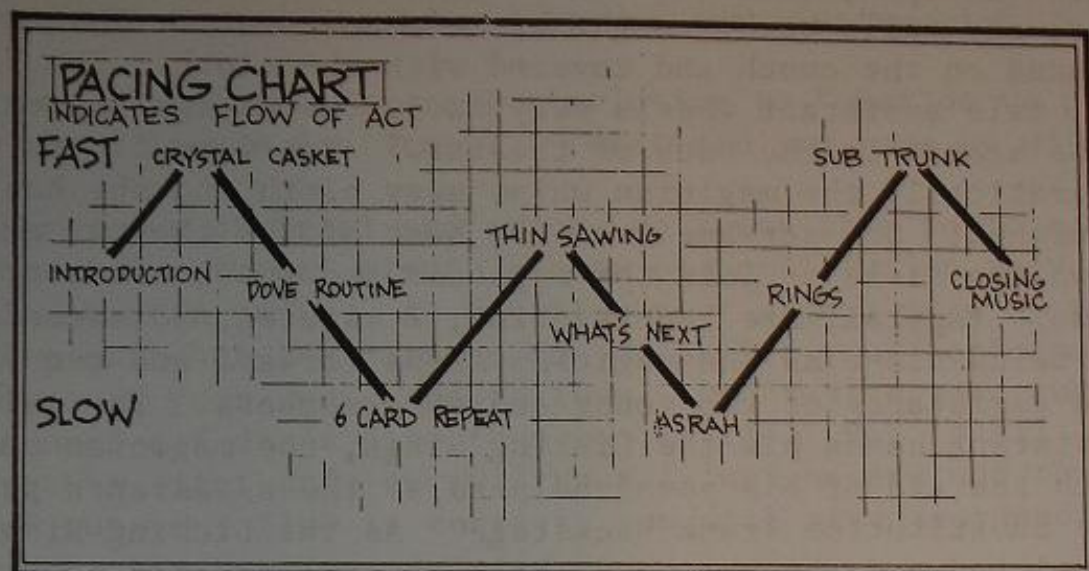
Remember, any successful show has peaks and valleys and they have to come at the right time. It took me several years to work out pacing for our park shows, but there is a formula for a good twenty minute illusion show. This formula is so successful that, season after season, we would substitute illusions, still keeping the same basic flow, and audiences around the world loved our shows.

To understand our illusion show formula remember what I said about peaks and valleys and begin to visualize it as if your show was a graph based on the high and low points.



The highest points being the illusions or effects that get the most audience reaction on a fast paced, up tempo level. The medium and slow effects are still good mysteries, they just run at a slower pace to allow your audience to catch their breath as they are still being entertained.

Let's use the same graph, but this time putting the effects in.



The act would basically flow like this: The magician is introduced, walks out to fast paced music. Enter assistant with crystal casket base and framework, the magician spins unit as assistant brings in plexi panels to insert into framework. Cloth cover is brought out, casket covered, unit revolved, girl produced. (Running time, approximately 2 minutes, 30 seconds.) Magician bows with female assistant. She exits, he begins blowing up balloon. Male assistant takes crystal casket off, brings on Dove to Duck. Female assistant enters with tray, balloon is attached - POP! A dove produced. Female assistant exits with tray, (changes costume backstage for sawing.) Dove is put in Dove to Duck box - BANG! Sides fall down - a rabbit is in the dove's place. Male assistant exits with the rabbit and the prop. (Running time, 1 minute.) Magician bows, steps up to microphone, removes six cards from pocket, begins patter - to finale of trick (approximate running time, 2 minutes.) Magician introduces the Thin Sawing In Half illusion. Curtain opens revealing the prop. Enter two assistants, the girl positioned in the box, the male assistant helps with blades, etc.. The illusion is performed to fast paced music to finale. Girl exits from box and curtains close. (Approximate running time, 2

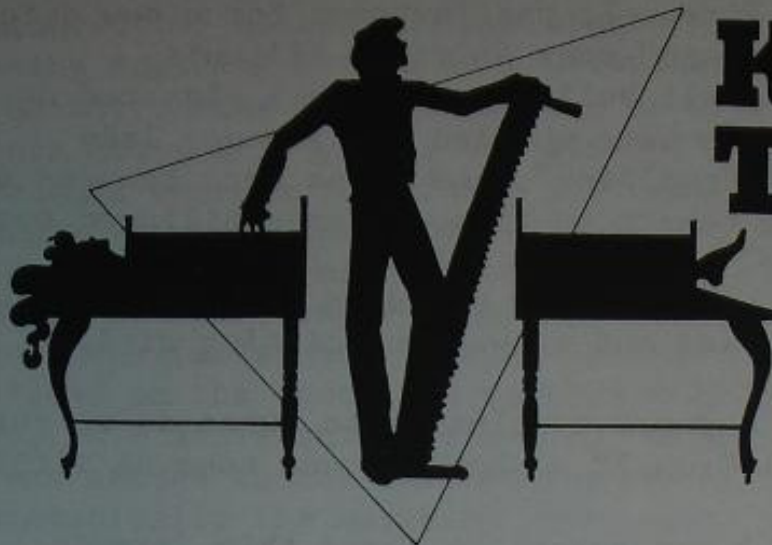
minutes, 45 seconds.) Assistants exit, male returns to bring magician What's Next effect as magician steps up to the microphone to begin patter on What's Next. Backstage both assistants preset the Asrah illusion, (girl assistant changes costume.) Magician performs What's Next to finale. (Approximate running time, 1 minute, 30 seconds.) Magician steps away from microphone as ethereal music begins. Curtains open, enter female assistant. Magician hypnotizes her, she falls back, caught by male assistant. She is placed on the couch and covered with the cloth. She floats up, male assistant wheels away table (backstage she exits, runs around to the back of theater.) The form floats up, dramatically the magician whips away cloth and she has vanished! She screams from the back of the theater and runs down the aisle to join the magician and the assistant for bows. (Approximate running time, 2 minutes, 30 seconds.) Curtains close as the magician steps forward and requests the assistance of two young audience members. The male assistant hands him the Linking Rings, the magician performs with the aid of his young helpers as the assistants prepare the Substitution Trunk backstage. As the Linking Rings are completed and the two young helpers are assisted back to their seats, the magician begins to talk about Houdini and his fabulous escapes. (Approximate running time, 3 minutes.) The up tempo music begins, the curtains open to reveal the trunk and the two assistants enter. The handcuffs and bag are displayed, the girl is cuffed and put in the bag. The bag is put in the trunk and tied off, the trunk is locked. The magician jumps on top of the trunk and pulls up the cloth cover. "One" (cover up, cover down), "two" (cover up, cover down), "three" (cover up, cover down) - it's her! She drops the cover, all is reversed and the magician is found where she once was! (Approximate running time, 3 minutes.) The magician and assistants take their well deserved bows.

This is the basic formula for our popular park shows. Season after season we would change the illusions out but never the formula. We changed the Sawing out for the Zig Zag, Cutting In Sixths and Mismade. The slot for the Crystal Casket was filled with the Costume Trunk, Doll House and Chef's Nightmare. The hardest slot to fill was the final illusion. The Sub Trunk is a natural conclusion to an illusion show. The Assistant's Revenge works nicely, the Zig Zag works okay and a costume switch works, but it has to be a special illusion to conclude your show. One of the most creative finale illusions we came up with was

called the Chicago Fire. It was invented for a now defunct park called "Old Chicago" near Chicago, Illinois. Basically it was a small building (cabinet) elevated on a parson's table. Steps were wheeled up, a young lady stepped up into the "building", the steps were removed and the little building caught on fire. Flames billowed out the top as "firemen" entered to put out the blaze. Instantly all four sides of the building collapsed. The firechief turned around and it was our missing girl!

It was a creative, expensive solution to "what do we put in place of the Sub Trunk?". What can you come up with?

After years of trial and error, we found this formula works for a twenty minute, three person illusion show presented in parks. As you plan your shows, draw my graph, write out what you plan to do, visualize your performance and gauge your peaks and valleys. Don't give your audience too much and don't give them too little. Put it all together right and, even if your illusions are not that good but your flow is correct, you will give your audience a memorable evening of magic.



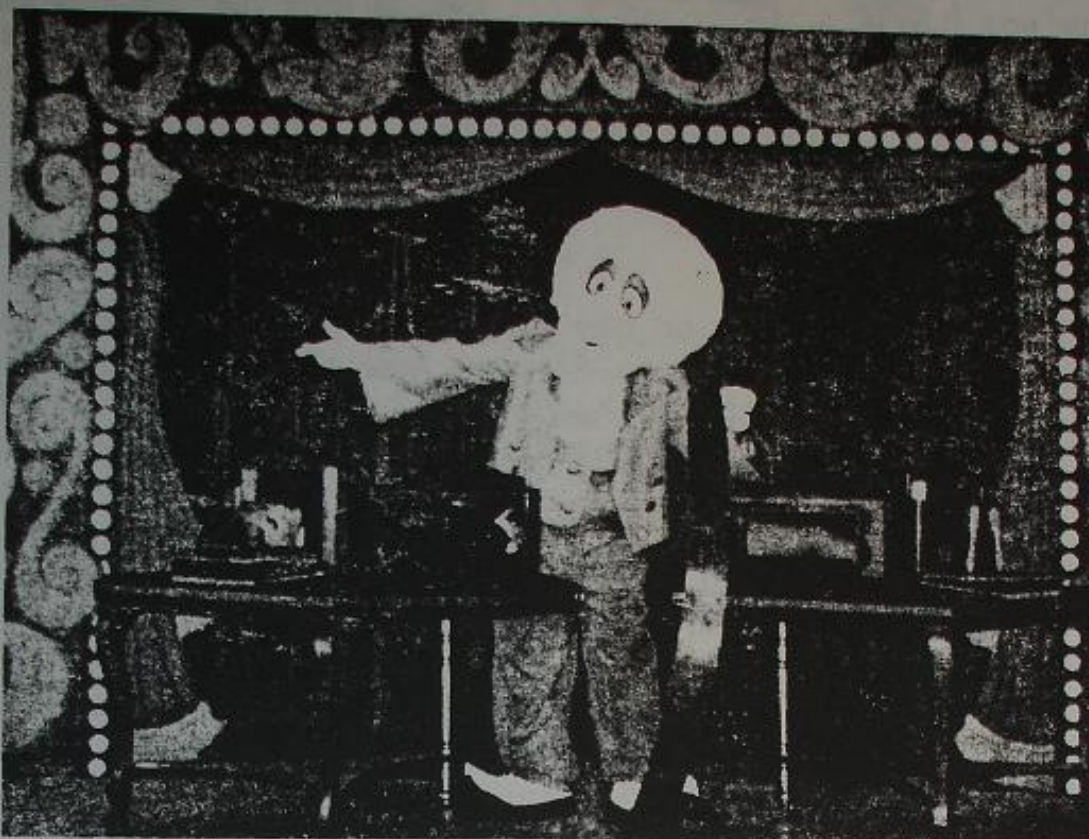
KNOW THYSELF

More and more it seems as though our knowledge of ourselves, both good and bad, will send us toward a success or failure. How we perceive ourselves is not necessarily how our audience sees us.

Earlier I mentioned a comparison between David Copperfield and Doug Henning and how their own images only reinforce what the audience already senses about these clever performers. That's why this chapter is in this book. Illusion planning should reflect you and your thoughts. Don't plan your act for some other magician. Be yourself.

Getting to know yourself as others see you is quite a trick, but the basic rule of thumb is doing what comes naturally. If one prop opens up new areas of patter or presentation for you and you enjoy it, use it and personalize it. If, on the other hand, another prop commonly used by magicians is awkward for you, don't use it. Begin practicing in the mirror a lot. Begin to play up your qualities, good or bad. Who knows, it may be your trade mark. The bottom line is, your props reflect you, so they should be props you enjoy performing, props themed to your liking and props that are performed only as you can perform them. Take the time to select your props as you would select a new suit and make sure they reflect your style.

All of the elements that surround your performance - your advertising, costuming, music and prop selection make up your image, or how people perceive you. Unfortunate as it may seem, in "show biz" your first impression may be your only chance. For that reason, you must have a clear view of yourself and your performance style to develop a distinctive approach. As you begin illusion planning, have a distinctive approach, don't copy and...know thyself



One of the most audience tested illusions is still the "Thin Model Sawing" performed here by "Hugo Greystone", our shopping center touring unit. Although the "feet switch" has some angle problems, when performed with fast stage activity, the exchange can be quickly hidden by a blade or a stock.

The "Thin Model Sawing" should definitely be part of your repertoire. When you hear that predictable gasp as the boxes are separated, you'll be hooked on this illusion.



BIRTHING

Whether you plan to buy one illusion to add to your existing show, or you plan to mount an entire production, you have to go through a stage I like to call "illusion birthing". Usually this phase takes place after your pre-production meetings, designs and plans.

At this point you must decide how the illusion is going to happen. Questions like "Will I buy the prop (?)", ".... make the prop (?)", "...have it made(?)", "Can I find a used one (?)", and "What length of time am I dealing with (?)", all must be answered. This "birthing" phase must be your most realistic.

When I began my amusement park business and our first magic show contracts began to roll in, I had no choice but to begin buying new illusions. They had to be custom made and I didn't have time to make them myself or train a carpenter. Little did I know that I was soon to be a magic manufacturing company. Over the years doing more and more shows, the simplest solution for us was to become our own supplier of illusions. It wasn't hard because we were also building scenery and stage props for various theatrical productions. The point here is, if you are going to buy the illusion, please allow your supplier the time to execute your prop with the skill and craftsmanship to which he is accustomed. You aren't the only order he has and, although you may just be ordering a Zig Zag, if he has to build Siegfried and Roy's new revue, you're going to have to wait. Having been a manufacturer and having been a customer, I can only tell you that you will have to be patient, have some front money and remember, if you ask your builder to invent the wheel and come up with a way to circulate real blood in the Sawing A Woman In Half feat, you are going to pay for it! So much for why I advocate building it yourself. And, chances are, if you do build it yourself, you are more

familiar with time tables, particularly your own, than most. If, on the other hand, you are going to solicit the help of a carpenter and this is the first time you've used him, you may want to factor in enough lead time to allow you to familiarize him with illusion building. If you've worked with him before, you should be familiar enough with his talents and timing. The message is always allow enough time for a good job. If it takes one boat seven days to sail from Galveston to Brazil will it take seven boats to make it in a day? No! And your illusion (in most cases) can't be built properly over night.

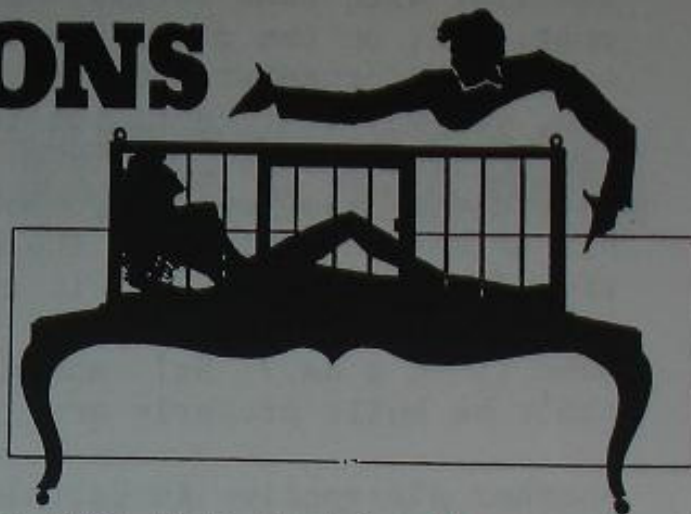
Another alternative in birthing illusions is the used market. If you are in the right place at the right time you can do quite well. Many times you can find a used prop, have it refurbished and repainted and end up with virtually a new prop for a lot less than you might have spent. I would strongly suggest you explore this avenue by checking the want ads in various magic magazines, going to auctions and talking to fellow magicians.

Well anyway, these are a few ways you can "birth" illusions. As I write this, I can't help but feel that time is more critical than money in finding, making or contracting your illusion. Be aware of this, be patient and let time work for you!

Remember the planning phase of any illusion show is also one of the most creative. If you are having an illusion built by a major magic builder, take the time to make sure your illusion is like no one else's. If you are buying plans and taking them to a local builder, change some things - colors, designs, or whatever to make that illusion more you. Use the planning phase to exercise your own creativity. For magic to work properly it has to be the perfect blend of fantasy and reality. It has to be impossible, but possible. You must walk this tightrope. Your creativity must develop the fun and fantasy side of your illusions and your realistic side will constantly have to watch time frames, costs, logistics, etc.. As you begin birthing illusions you will soon find you are behaving like Jekyll and Hyde.

Buying used magic is also an excellent opportunity to begin fixing up old illusions and learning how to build your own as you work on the existing props.

CONDITIONS



Now that we all agree that your show should reflect you and not some other magician, what are the other elements that effect illusion planning? Conditions would be number one. What type of conditions will you be presenting your show or new illusion under? Will it be on stages at schools; surrounded in churches; outdoors; indoors; at night; during the day; with backstage; no backstage; three shows a day; one show a day; carry it in a Volkswagon; carry it in a truck; travel far; travel across the street; with no assistants; with two assistants; or ten dancers????

You must define these elements. What type of conditions do you envision yourself working under? School shows have different requirements than amusement parks. All I can do is ask the questions that you should be asking of yourself. Will you require lighting? If so, how much and what is the cost? Music...do you record it yourself? Where do you get the costumes? Again, more questions to ask of yourself. In many instances the answer to your questions has a financial answer - too expensive! If you are planning an illusion show for profit, remember one golden rule of business, you must make more than you spend.

Hopefully, I can answer some of the questions I have just posed. I can't help you with the conditions under which you hope to perform. Just remember to be aware of them and plan for them. Lighting is, in most cases, a luxury and you shouldn't have to supply your own. Most stages have some form of equipment. It's to what degree that your show requires lighting that you must address yourself. If you plan an entire black-art number, you will have to supply your own specialty lighting. Music is a critical element of any illusion show. Generally the music track, or background is cut after all the props are assembled. Rehearsals are staged and timed. At that

point you'll know the Doll House number is two minutes long, etc. Then, it's off to the record store. Buy records you think might work and audition and time them at home. Assign a time and album cut to each effect before you head for the recording studio. Preproduction and planning can save you a great deal of money as most studios charge by the hour. If it takes you any longer than two hours to put together a twenty minute show, recording studio wise, you may want to examine your preproduction. And if you have any illusion over 2 1/2 minutes in length, it had better be a good one!

And now a little trick that could save you hundreds of dollars. Get to know your local radio station disc jockey. Do a few trade-outs, appear at local sporting events wearing a station T-shirt doing magic, or whatever. Just get in with the station because once you have done them some favors maybe, just maybe they'll give you access to their music library and help you put together your audio tape - announcers, music and all - for free. Remember, record stores don't let you listen before you buy and recording studios charge by the hour, but radio stations have recording equipment and record libraries. Get to know your local radio station.

Costumes are a nice addition to any illusion show. Your budget should dictate this item. Your local fabric store can yield loads of costume ideas within the pages of Simplicity, Butterick, McCalls and Vogue pattern books. Most spare-time seamstresses check in or leave business cards at the front desk. Couple this information with your own creativity of changing patterns, adding rhinestones, etc. and you have a costume. Just make sure the costume you have in mind will work with the illusion you have in mind. Be your own critic, work in advance and pre-produce.

I have taken an average pattern as you would find in the fabric stores and with some tracing paper made a few changes in the basic design. I added a bow tie and collar to give this a magical assistant's look. The modifications are simple enough with tracing paper and when you take the pattern and your tracing to a competent seamstress, she should be able to go from that. Remember too, that this same seamstress can probably make your dove bags, cage covers, etc..

BUTTERICK

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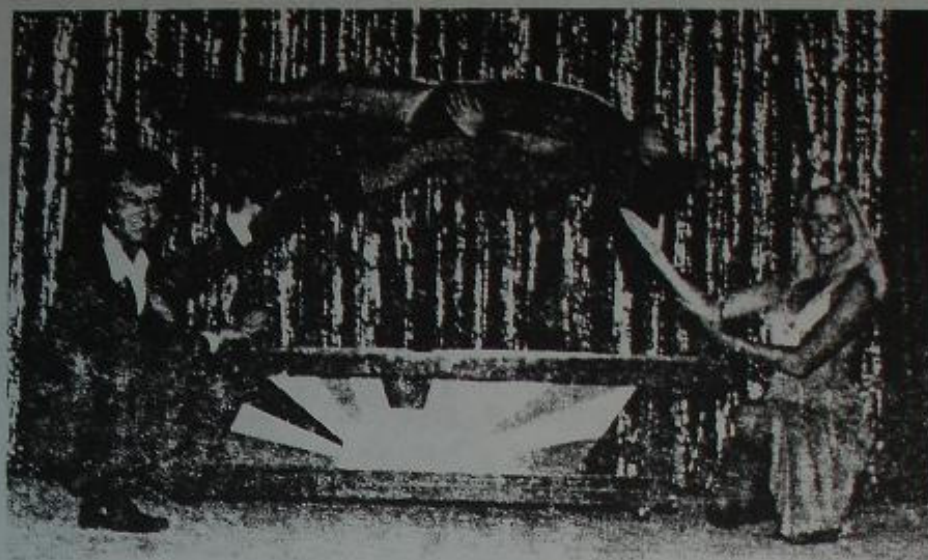
NEW
Sizing



6 8 10 12



The conditions under which you perform will make all the difference in the world. I once bought Abbott's Cage illusion, the one where the girl and the cage vanish. It was a good prop but I couldn't use it all the time because many stages were not set up to hoist the (?) cage. So, I could have done better in my illusion planning. The one thing I always forget about is wind and outdoor stages. Forget flash pots and weight down crystal casket covers, etc.. One time one of our amusement park magicians stepped forward with the covered cage of doves all set to vanish them and up pops a gust of wind, showing all that the miracle had, in fact, happened some time ago - there was no cage of doves under that cloth. One of the great illusions of all time is the "Zig Zag", primarily because it can work under any conditions. Plan your illusions for your conditions.



If you are planning on adding a Levitation to your act, remember you have to have a backstage, a curtain and an operator. If this isn't possible, a "Super X" type suspension may be for you.



Some illusions require special angles. The "Three Fold Screen" can only best be done with the audience sitting straight on. In planning your illusion show consider angles.



REHEARSAL

A big part of adding that illusion or modifying your show is, of course, rehearsal. Our amusement park shows generally run twenty to thirty minutes, have four to five major illusions and require two weeks of rehearsal. Each show segment is thoroughly thought out and planned even prior to shipping out the props.

When we are working on a new illusion or one that hasn't been pre-staged we first play with it, find out its capabilities and its bad points. Just good, old fashioned horse play can net some great results. One time, for one of our Six Flags shows we added a "Princess Of Thebes". Purely by accident we found that the male assistant could open the top door of the box and place his arm and hand in in such a fashion to look like the girl was reaching out of the box, (she, of course, had long gone into the base). So we put it in the show and it added a nice touch to that prop. The girl goes in box...box hoisted up...base (and girl) wheeled away...male assistant opens lid to box... she (?) reaches out to slap him...fanfare...sides fall down on box...it's empty! A nice piece of business that wouldn't have happened had we not played with the prop. Always be open to a nice surprise such as that, but also approach each illusion with a basic performance concept and work toward a goal.

Our step-by-step process is as follows:

1. Play with illusion - form basic performance concepts.
2. Call in assistants and walk through effect.
3. Time basic rehearsal.
4. Select music - rough cut to illusion time.

5. Rehearse until perfect.

6. Dress rehearsal.

The first four steps are one third of the entire process and just the preliminaries. The remaining two thirds is to rehearse, rehearse, rehearse.

A good estimate is anywhere from eight to fifteen full hours of rehearsal per illusion, depending on its complexity.



CRATING

If you are traveling with a show, one of your most important elements will be the crating. It is an expenditure your audience will never see, but one that is required if you are to keep your props and costumes in good shape.

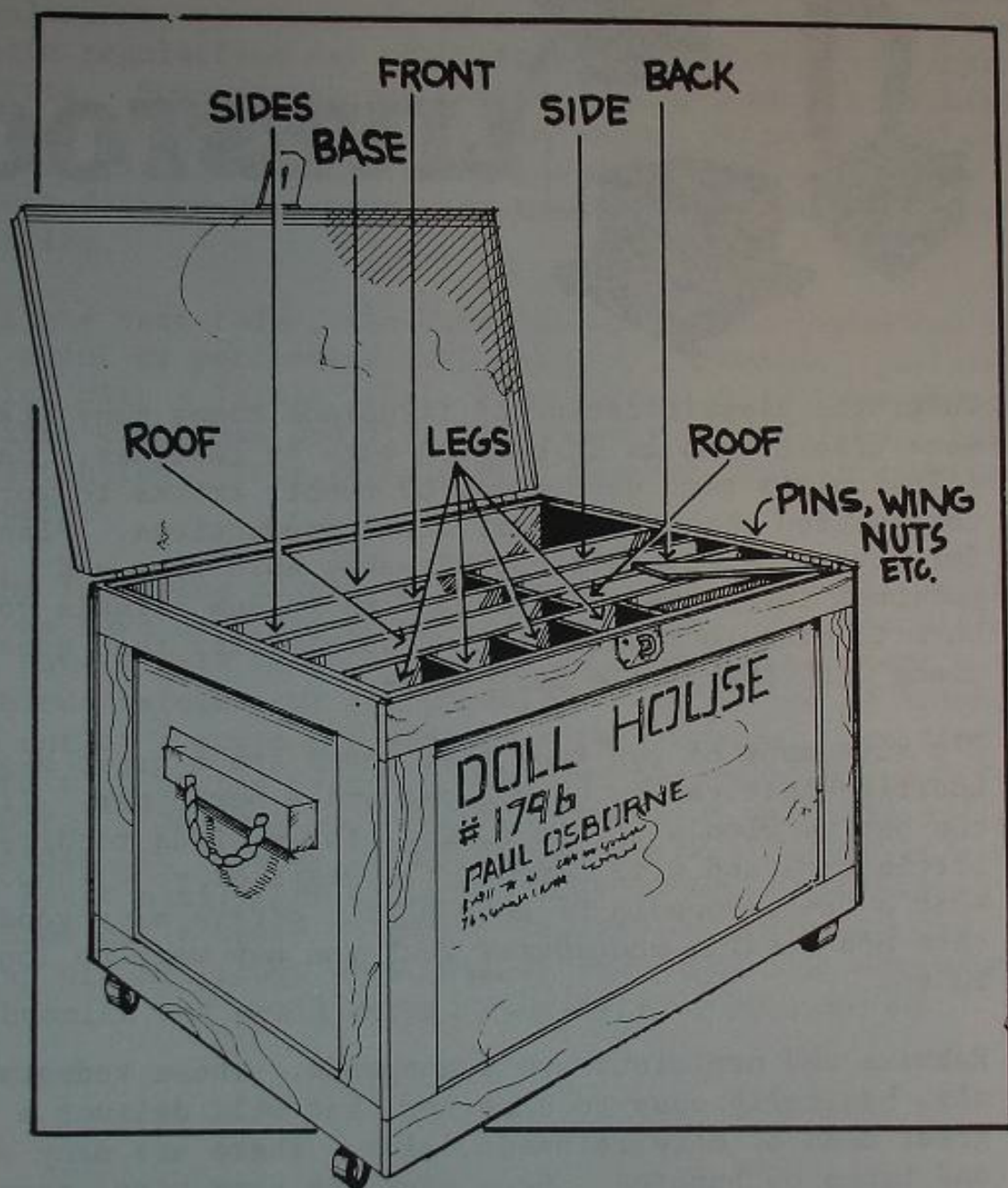
Nowadays many magic builders make available to their customers the "Anvil" style crates. These are basic wood crates, covered in ABS plastic with aluminum extruded edging, trim and corners. These cases feature various locking and hinging mechanisms with foam lining inside and partitioning, if needed. In most situations this is the most expensive type crating but well worth it if your travel schedule is hectic. The anvil type cases do an excellent job of protecting your props and, if you have the money, they are well worth it.

However, if you can build your own illusions, you can also do a pretty decent job of building your own cases as well. The main idea of crating is organization - getting as much as possible in a small space. Also, protection for your prop is most important. In most cases the crate for each illusion will contain all the elements for that prop, the base, legs, sides, top, swords, blades and even pin hinges. I have illustrated a typical type of crate you can make yourself or have made. To help keep track of what is in each crate we would number them and maintain a master packing list with a full inventory. If you plan on traveling with many illusions, this is a good system. If you are just adding one or two new effects, you don't have to get too fancy, yet.

Properly crating and shipping your show is a large part of illusion planning and you should also plan this aspect during your pre-production phase. If done properly, your

props will last an indefinite amount of time and you will be pleased that you spent the time and money to properly protect and transport your props.

The illustrated crate is pretty typical of the type we use when we build a crate. Of course, the degree to which you want to protect the prop dictates the type of wood, but basically we would use 3/8" ply framed with 1" x 6". Each illusion piece would have its own compartment lined with foam rubber, material or indoor/outdoor carpeting. In each crate we included a miscellaneous compartment to hold pins, wing nuts, etc.. We lock our crates in front and heavy duty rubber casters are always worth it. We include rope handles as needed. It is best to paint the outside of all your crates the same color and stencil all needed information on the front. A good crate will extend the life of your illusion beyond your expectations.





LIVESTOCK

Under the classification of illusions comes many stage size tricks used as in between acts or routines. Many illusionists plan dove, duck or rabbit tricks to work in conjunction with the larger scale productions. Planning for livestock involves considerably more time and personal involvement. If you plan to use animals you have to plan to take on the responsibility that goes along with the little performers.

I'm sure many of you know that doves are a great magical addition that can be both a pet and a performer. If you can put up with a little cooing, these birds require little care and will soon be the stars of your show. Ian Adar's "Encyclopedia Of Dove Magic" offers many good care and feeding procedures that you may want to look in to.

Rabbits and magicians are synonymous. These rodents are also basically easy to care for, but will deliver a great deal of entertainment value. There are many styles and types of bunnies. Some stay the same size, some grow rapidly and some have varying degrees of temperament and personalities. Before buying this little performer, make sure you research the type of rabbit that best suits your act and one that won't out grow your props in two weeks.

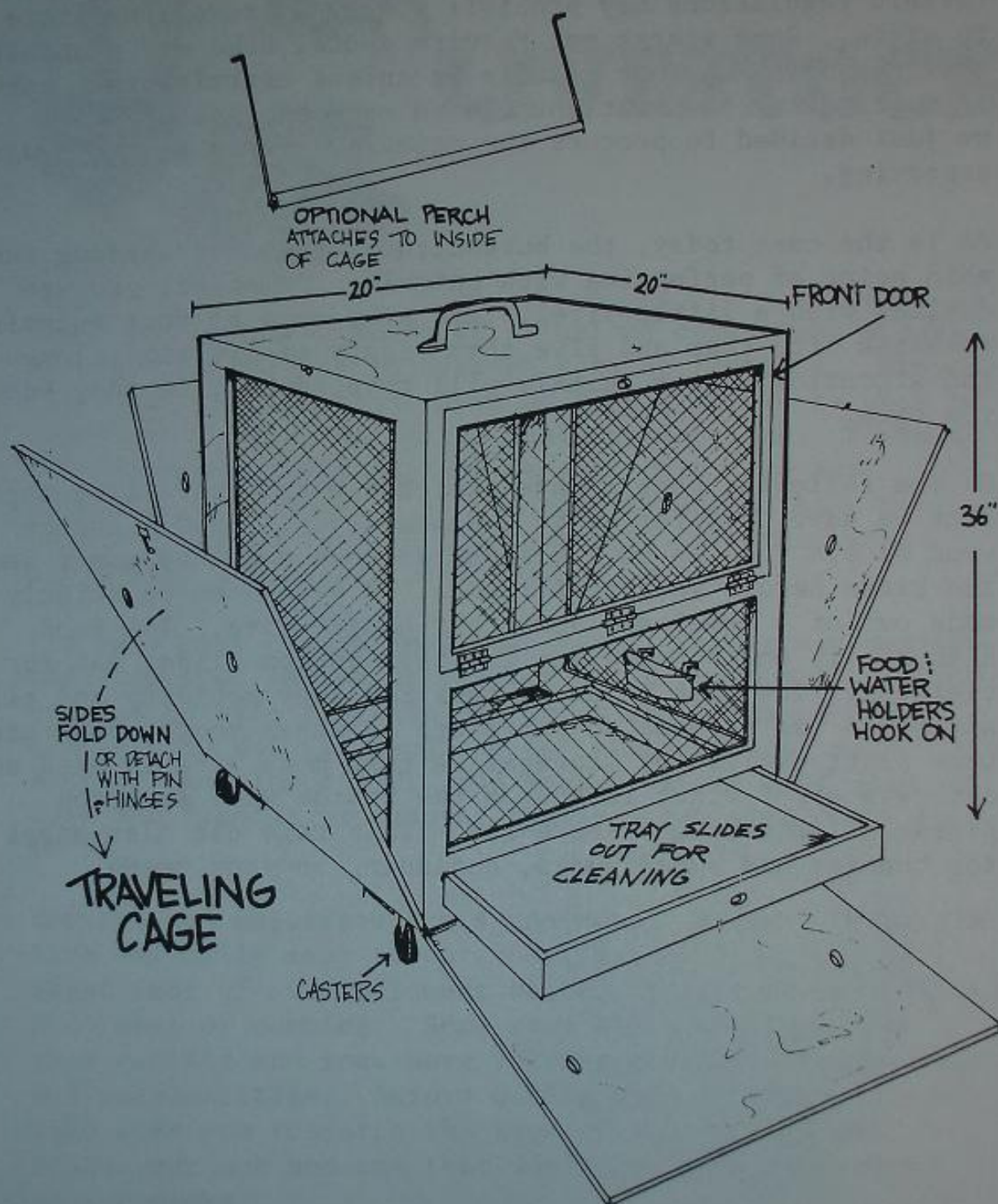
Have you ever worked with ducks? I have. Ducks really belong in the lake. No, they can be taught basics; but only with a great deal of patience, and it helps if you work with them beginning when they are babies. Their

"foldability" is surprising, even to them, and you'll find that continuous rehearsal is required to teach them that they can, indeed, fold up in small places.

Nowadays, working with any animals involves a great deal of pre-planning, particularly if you plan to travel with them. Certain regulations may prohibit you from travelling state to state. Some states may require shots, some may prohibit you from bringing your animals in unless certain paper work is up to date. We went through so many hassles one time we just decided to procure the animals in each state we were appearing.

As is the case today, the bureaucracy often overshadows the main point of performing with animals. Remember, you are dealing with a little life. Take good care of your animals, rehearse with them and give them plenty of off time, love and attention. Your animals will respond best if they know you care.

On the following page I have sketched out a travelling cage that we have used for up to a dozen doves. You'll notice wood panels fold up on the sides so your audience won't see the birds before your performance. A perch can be quickly made out of a dowel and some coat hanger wire. The food dishes clip on the side and the tray bottom slides out for cleaning. The unit is on casters for easy mobility and all six sides can be made to pin-hinge together so the cage can tear apart easily for storage. A thin mesh wire is used so cat paws can't reach in and on the inside make sure you finish off all rough wire edges. This cage can also adapt for bunnies and small ducks, depending on your needs.





FINALLY...

Presenting illusions can be one of your most rewarding experiences. Building your own effects can be even more rewarding. But, as I have said before, getting there can be half the fun and if you take time to not only plan your illusion presentations, but also your entire act, the reward will definitely be there.

It is my sincere hope that as you begin illusion planning you will insert some of your own inborn creativity to make your presentations one of a kind. As this book is being written, the new "stars of illusion" are each one of a kind Henning, Le Grande David, Copperfield, Seigfreid and Roy. Their originality not only in performing, but also in conceptualizing, promotion and final execution will keep them at the top. It is this drive for originality, uniqueness and entertainment value that I hope to tap into with this publication and the many do-it-yourself plans, magazine contributions and Illusion Systems products.

Psychologists have often said, "If, just once in our lives, we don't do something that is a little scary, we aren't living life to its fullest." It is my hope that this year you will do something a little scary - create. People may hate it, but create. Call upon your own powers of originality and do something different. Add an illusion to your act, build an illusion, invent an illusion - it doesn't matter what, as long as it is of your own doing. It is my hope that this booklet will provide you with the information of my successes and failures so that you may use them in your illusion planning.